Adora Has A Magic Sword And She's Not Afraid To Use It

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31160984.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Kyle & Lonnie & Rogelio (She-Ra), Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Original Female Character(s), Angella (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Swift Wind (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Baker (She-Ra), Busgirl (She-Ra), Soda Pop (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Sequel time!, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018) Season 1, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Karma AU, Minor Catradora, And other ships, no swearing in my Christian Minecraft server, please and thank you, Rogelio uses sign language, because I say so, Fluff and Angst, Family Shenanigans, Nicknames, so many nicknames, will update randomly, Because I don't have a train of thought I have a Knight Bus of thought, So many kids have been adopted, both emotionally and legally, So the Catradora is actually not very background anymore because it wanted to not be, Oops?

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Part 2 of Karma's Kittens AU

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by orphan_account

Summary

THIS IS A SERIES, READ THE FIRST WORK FIRST.

Season one in the Karma's Kittens AU! Glimmer and Catra are set on fighting in the war, Angella and Karma try to parent six teenagers at once, and Kyle and Rogelio just want some peace and quiet.

Notes

YAY WE'RE FINALLY HERE.

I finally get to introduce our new Horde antagonists! (Since I got the originals adopted. Oops?). Hopefully they're just as varied and intriguing as the first ones.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra Would Like To Blow Something Up Now Please

When you are in the Horde, it feels like the Horde owns you. It feels like being part of a machine run on the energy of its people, and one day you would run out of energy and be left behind.

Rosa didn't ever intend to be left behind.

She stared at herself in the mirror. Her ghostly white hair was cropped short, framing her pale face. Her red eyes shone with a kind of dangerous intelligence only a fool would underestimate.

The world was full of fools, unfortunately.

She finished buckling her equipment on. Time to prove to this imbeciles her intellectual superiority.

"All squadrons, report to the training area immediately for evaluation." Rosa smirked. She could do this. She was *born* for this.

She made her way to the training area, leisurely selecting a glowing pink spot. When she stepped on it, it turned toxic green. A bit symbolic, she thought with a wry grin.

Her squad members soon joined her. Pugna, a wolflike girl with big turquoise eyes, wild brown hair, and a fluffy black tail. Tina, a tiny young woman with black hair perpetually tied in twin buns. Will, neat blond hair combed to perfection. Victor, his dark magenta horns nearly obscured by his curly dust-colored hair.

"At attention, cadets. Your simulation is about to begin. Here's your scenario." The instructor was a buff teal man whose eyes eerily resembled the creepy imp Rosa had seen from time to time spying on people. He had a stern, no-nonsense look on his face.

He clicked a button and the screen behind him lit up, showing an ominously dark and *obviously* exaggerated forest. Rosa resisted the temptation to roll her eyes at the Horde's blatant brainwashing. "You'll be passing through the heart of the Whispering Woods to reach the heart of the rebel insurgence, Bright Moon."

Tina gulped nervously, one finger worrying a loose strand of hair.

"Your mission is to defeat the Queens of the Princesses and liberate Bright Moon in Lord Hordak's name," the instructor continued. "Any questions?"

"Yeah," Victor said. "Do you actually expect us to do anything?"

"Victor!" Will snapped.

The instructor groaned. “The Whispering Woods is full of princesses. Vicious, violent instigators.” As he spoke, the doors opened behind him. “They will take you out if given the chance. Don’t give it to them. Good luck, recruits.”

Rosa approached the simulation, adjusting her green-tinted visor. She quickly spotted a ‘princess’- really a Horde bot- that fired on them.

Rosa dodged the blasts, calmly noting four hostiles. Pugna immediately began hammering away at the nearest bot, her brute strength and surprisingly agility allowing her to take it down with relative ease. Victor swiftly got out- likely on purpose. Because he was the worst.

Will and Tina chose to dodge, occasionally landing glancing blows on the bots. Rosa pulled out her weapon of choice- a pair of hook swords.

She slipped under the closest bot, analyzing the paneling. Rosa had studied Horde bots’ anatomy, and if her studies were correct- *there* .

She jabbed her hook swords through the crack where two panels met, and twisted sharply, impaling the central processing unit. As expected, the bot shut down immediately.

Rosa smirked. She withdrew her swords, and continued forward.

Their group proceeded more or less together, avoiding fire and navigating obstacles.

Tina was hit first- an expected casualty. They left her- nothing they could do for her anyways. The three remaining members crossed a clearing, red hexagons flashing ominously red beneath their feet.

Suddenly, a pair of new bots rose from the floor, bigger than any before. Rosa's visor showed her an image of a cackling queen and a catlike woman with bared fangs.

They began to fire at them. Will was hit- unexpected, but not necessarily devastating to her chances. Pugna was her best asset.

"Pugna!" she called. "Take out the bots! The sensors are most vulnerable!"

Pugna gave her a half feral grin before leaping onto the bots, making swift work of them. Rosa nodded approvingly.

Soon I'll be out there. And then the world itself will shake.

. . .

"How much trouble do you think we're in?" Adora whispered.

"Probably a lot," Catra replied nonchalantly.

"Well, let's get this over with," Glimmer said, tugging the two into the throne room.

Queen Angella and Queen Karma sat side by side, the picture of intimidating regality. Angella's face was stern, while the other queen looked faintly amused.

The three girls knelt. "Your majesties," Glimmer said respectfully.

"I'm told you disobeyed orders and led the Rebellion into a dangerous combat situation after you were ordered to retreat," Angella said without preamble.

Glimmer winced. "We were just trying to protect a village from falling into the Horde's grasp."

"Which was like, our *job* ?" Catra added.

“You were reckless and put yourselves and the other rebels in danger.”

“Oh no, the army? In *danger* ?” Catra fake gasped. “Not like they fight for a living or anything.”

Karma snorted. “Sunshine, are you even *trying* to get out of trouble?”

Catra shrugged rebelliously. “I call ‘em like I see ‘em.”

“Anyways, we are never going to beat the Horde by retreating!” Adora claimed.

“We need to hold our ground *somewhere* !” agreed Glimmer. “Pretty soon we won’t have anything left to defend!”

“I’m growing tired of your back-talking, Commander Glimmer, Commander Adora, Commander Catra.” Angella snapped, rising from her throne.

“Why even make us commanders if you won’t let us fight?” Glimmer demanded.

“We aren’t babies anymore Mom,” Catra said.

Adora nodded. “We can fight!”

“That’s enough!” Angella shouted. “You three are grounded!”

“Mom!” the three young girls all cried, aghast.

“You heard your mom,” Karma said. “You disobeyed military orders, there’s got to be some punishment.”

“You never let us do anything!” Glimmer yelled.

“We aren’t made of glass!” Adora tacked on.

“Kittens-“ Karma began, only to be cut off by Angella.

“We’re not having this discussion tonight. You three are embarrassing me in front of my Royal Court.”

“Oh, *we’re* embarrassing *you* ?” Catra snarked. “That’s definitely what’s happening here.”

“Go to your rooms!” Angella ordered, wings flaring out.

“Fine!” Glimmer shouted. “We’re going!”

The three girls stomped out. Angella sighed. “Do you think I was too harsh?” she asked Karma.

Karma shook her head. “They need to learn to follow orders, and if we let them get away with it they’ll never learn. They’re tough kittens, they can take a little scolding.” She paused. “Though perhaps we should make sure to spend some time with them, show we’re not mad, just worried.”

Angella nodded, sitting back down next to her friend.

. . .

“Cadet Rosa,” Shadow Weaver’s cold voice intoned. The sorceress melted out of the darkness, her mask’s eyes boring into the young woman.

Rosa nodded to her mentor. “Shadow Weaver.”

“As expected, your squad performed well,” Shadow Weaver praised her. “I have good news. Lord Hordak has recognized your

devotion. He thinks you are a fine candidate for Force Captain."

The corners of Rosa's mouth rose. She'd been expecting this, but that didn't make it less satisfying. "Understood. Is this a promotion or mere encouragement?"

"A promotion," the older woman said. "You will lead your team to capture the rebel Fortress of Thaymor."

"Understood," Rosa replied. "What's the timetable?"

Though Rosa couldn't see Shadow Weaver's face, she sounded like she was smiling. "I knew you were the right choice."

. . .

"Ughhh," Catra groaned. "I'm so *bored* ." She flopped on Glimmer's bed, where she had been sulking for the past half hour.

"Well too bad," Glimmer replied, annoyed. She was perched on the windowsill, scribbling angrily in a journal."Since we're *grounded* ."

"How long do you think we're gonna be grounded for?" Adora wondered, leaning against the wall.

“Eternity,” Catra deadpanned.

The door opened and Kyle and Rogelio walked in. Kyle was carrying a tray of cookies.

“Kyle! Rogelio!” Adora cried, hugging them both.

Catra hopped down to greet her brothers. “Those cookies for me?”

Kyle held them back, glaring. “These cookies are for sisters who *didn’t* almost get themselves killed.”

“So, not for Glimmer then.”

“ *Hey* !”

‘Welcome back,’ Rogelio signed. ‘The castle was quiet without any of you blowing things up.’

“I *want* to blow things up,” Catra grumbled. “But we’re *grounded* .”

“When has that ever stopped you before?” Kyle muttered, munching on a cookie.

“Mom treats us like *children* !” Glimmer complained. “We are *capable* ! We can fight! It’s like she doesn’t respect us!”

An arrow thudded next to Glimmer, making everyone jump. Glimmer grabbed the note attached, then announced, “Bow’s here!”

“Great, I want him to try this new recipe!”

“Oh, so *he* gets cookies? Low blow, little brother.”

“Watch it!” Glimmer whisper-yelled out the window. “You almost hit me!”

“HEY GUYS!” Bow yelled outside.

“Shh!” Glimmer hissed, waving her hands frantically. The rest of the group joined her at the window. “Bow, what are you doing here?”

“WHAT DID YOU SAY? COME DOWN HERE!” Bow replied, just as loud as before.

Catra facepalmed.

“We can’t!” Adora responded, in the same low tone as Glimmer. “We’re grounded.”

“WHAT?” Bow said.

More vehemently, Glimmer repeated, “We’re grounded!”

Bow paused. Then he yelled again, “WHAT?”

“Just get the idiot,” Catra shrugged. “No one here will tell, right?” She mock-glared at everyone.

“Sure,” Kyle agreed. “We haven’t had a Chill Bros meeting for a while.”

Glimmer sighed, then quickly teleported to Bow and brought him into her room. The Bright Moon wards greeted him with varying levels of enthusiasm.

Glimmer started to rant again. “I’m so mad at Mom!”

Bow winced in sympathy. “Is this about the siege on Elbernon?”

“YES!” Adora shouted. “We made an informed decision and they’re acting like we’re idiots!”

“Yeah,” Catra agreed. “Only two of the three were idiots. I’m innocent.”

“CATRA!”

“That’s my name, don’t wear it out.”

“All we were doing was defending another one of our villages from falling into the Horde’s clutches!” Glimmer continued, ignoring Catra and Adora’s bickering. “She stationed us all the way out there because it’s too remote to ever get attacked, but then it *did* , and it was our one chance to prove we could do this. But she acts like we can’t do anything, because we’re just princesses.”

Adora coughed. “I’m not.”

“Or me,” Bow pointed out. “We’re like the only ones who aren’t princesses.”

“Hey!” Kyle objected. “What about me and Rogelio?!”

“You’re the prettiest princesses of us all,” Catra snickered. “Obviously.”

“You guys are the *worst* .”

“I try.”

Bow started cleaning Glimmer’s room. “Anyway, your mom might have a point. The only reason Glimmer and Adora got out of there was her teleportation powers, and let’s face it, they don’t always work that well.”

“I was fine,” Catra said. “It’s the others who should be grounded.”

“You have no loyalty.”

“I’m a cat, comes with the territory.”

“If you wanna prove yourself, you can’t just run recklessly into battle,” Kyle said, handing Bow a cookie. “Mama got where she is by strategy, not impulsiveness.”

“I mean there was that time she broke into the Fright Zone,” Catra muttered.

Bow lit up. “I’ve got just the thing! Check this out!” He pulled out his tracker pad, displaying it to the Bright Moon teenagers. “I detected a piece of First Ones tech in the Whispering Woods. A pretty powerful one, too, by the size of these readings. If you bring it back, your mom is bound to be impressed.”

“Did you forget they’re grounded?” Kyle pointed out.

“If we find it and bring it back, Mom might unground us,” Catra said slyly.

“Still, we’d be breaking the rules…” Adora hesitated.

A loud knock came from the door. “Glimmer?” Angella said. “I heard voices, is someone else in there?”

Glimmer opened the door. “It’s just me, Adora, Catra, and the boys. We’re family, we’re allowed to spend time together. Or is that not allowed too?”

“I don’t appreciate your tone young lady,” Angella snapped.

“What tone?”

“That attitude of yours-“

“Mom!”

The argument continued, and all the rest of the teenagers waited awkwardly by the windowsill. Finally, Glimmer slammed the door. “I’m in. Anyone else?”

“Me,” Catra raised a hand.

“I guess I’m in,” Adora said reluctantly.

“I’m gonna stay here,” Kyle decided. “Rogelio?”

‘I’d rather finish this book,’ Rogelio agreed. ‘Can I have more cookies?’

"Sure thing."

. . .

A few hours later, the four teenagers found themselves wandering through the woods, Bow messing with his tracker pad.

"Come on, come on!"

Adora groaned. "Are we lost?"

"Please tell me we're not lost," Glimmer sighed, hands on her hips.

"No, this thing is just acting up." Bow replied.

"That's *way* better," Catra sassed him, not looking unduly concerned.

"No, it's good!" Bow insisted. "It looks like it's being overloaded by the tech's signal. We must be getting close!"

Glimmer gasped, pointing at some light. "Uh… I think it's this way."

“What makes you say that?” Bow questioned.

“The unnatural light over there?” Catra deadpanned. Adora smacked her arm. “What? It’s not like it wasn’t obvious.”

The group made their way through the brush, emerging into a clearing. Adora and Bow both gasped. There was a beautiful sword tangled in some plants, glowing brightly.

“Whoa,” Glimmer breathed.

“Not bad,” Catra admitted.

Adora walked over and went to pick it up. Suddenly she cried out, falling to the ground.

“Adora!” Catra yelped. They rushed over to the prone girl, checking to ensure she was breathing.

“Wh’re you?” Adora mumbled. “Goin’ on? The swor…”

“Oh great, she’s brain damaged,” Catra moaned. “Our moms are gonna kill us.”

Adora blinked awake. “Unnngh,” she grunted, sitting up. “What happened?”

“You touched the sword and passed out,” Glimmer told her. “Do you remember anything?”

“Grayskull?” Adora replied.

“Yup, brain damaged,” Catra muttered.

Bow walked over and picked up the sword carefully. Nothing happened. “Huh. Maybe it was a one time thing?”

“Or maybe it hates Adora,” Glimmer worried. “Just to be safe, I’ll carry it.” Bow passed her the sword.

“Well, it seems powerful,” Bow concluded. “Let’s bring it back to Bright Moon.”

. . .

Some time later, they were lost.

“Are you positive we’re going the right way Glimmer?” Bow asked hesitantly.

“I know what I’m doing!” Glimmer snapped defensively. “Can you please just trust me?”

“Glimmer, I trust you with a lot of things,” Catra replied. “Navigation is not one of them.”

“I pretty much grew up in these woods, and I’ve never seen this part of them,” Bow warned. “I’ve heard stories about weird stuff out here.”

“It’s fine, okay? Just let me figure this out!” Glimmer responded, teleporting ahead.

“Ok *ay* , touchy,” Bow muttered.

“Sparkles gets snappy when she’s worried,” Catra said sagely.

Up ahead, Glimmer began to cry. Alarmed, the rest of the group sprinted over to find her in front of a ruined village.

“Oh no,” Adora said softly.

Catra ran a hand against a decimated wall. “This could’ve been my village,” she whispered. “The one I was born in.”

“Imagine if we really grew up in the Horde,” Adora pondered. “We could’ve been part of the raiding party who did this. We could think this was *right* .”

Catra nodded mutely.

“Maybe we’d still be friends though?” Bow suggested. “Adora would probably defect rather than hurt innocent people.”

“You all should be grateful I’m on your side,” Catra joked weakly. “I’d be an evil mastermind.”

Glimmer started screaming. She ran out from behind the nearby trees, sword held in front of her. “There’s something out there! Something big!”

“How big?” Bow demanded, pulling an arrow out of his quiver. The ground rumbled, and a giant bug like creature burst into the clearing.

“Oh. So pretty big then,” Bow said faintly.

The bug screeched and charged at them. Glimmer was nearly trampled, but managed to teleport away just in time. She leapt onto the bug’s face, using her powers to blast it. She landed next to the others.

The bug stumbled back, now angrier than before. Catra jumped on its back, trying to find a weak point. Adora’s foot slipped into a crack in the ground, making it difficult to move. She could only watch as the bug approached her.

Bow stepped in front of her and shot an arrow that cover the bug’s mouth with goo. Glimmer shot blast after blast of magic, succeeding only on getting herself thrown into a tree. Bow managed to get a rope around one of the creature’s horns. Catra jumped down to help him hold the bug back.

Adora managed to get her foot free, and quickly scanned the battle for weapons. She spotted the discarded sword.

Bow and Catra were thrown onto Glimmer, who desperately held back the bug using her magic. Adora picked up the sword, determined to protect her family.

“Hey bug brain!” Adora yelled, holding the sword up. “Come on, magic sword… where’s a blinding flash of light when you need one?!”

The bug charged.

Adora panicked, visions running through her head. “For the honor of Grayskull!” Adora yelled.

Light flared, and where the disheveled young girl was standing, a dazzling warrior stood in her place.

Have You Tried Turning Your Hologram On And Back Off Again?

Chapter Notes

Welcome back to the madness. I apologize in advance.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For a moment, all was still. The bug silently backed down, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow stared at their friend.

Then Adora screamed. “Holy crap, I’m *buff* !”

“Oh, this isn’t a hallucination,” Catra muttered.

“Could be a shared one,” Bow suggested.

Adora flailed and landed on her backside, herself again.

“Adora!” Catra yelled, running over to her friend. “You okay?”

Adora had a ridiculous grin. “Heeeeey, Catra?” she sing-songed. “I don’t know how tall I was, but probably more than seven feet…”

Catra frowned, confused. Then her eyes widened and she slapped Adora. “How do you still remember that?!”

Glimmer and Bow walked over. “What are you talking about?” Bow asked.

“Catra’s gonna marry me!” Adora grinned, leaning on the sword. “She promised.”

“What?”

“I was four!” Catra shrieked, tail sticking straight up in annoyance. She snatched the sword out from under Adora, causing the blonde to fall over.

As soon as the sword left Adora’s hands, the bug woke. It rose to its feet, towering over the four teenagers.

“Time to run,” Catra announced, grabbing her friends.

“Why don’t I just do what I did before?” Adora suggested.

“Do you *know* what you did before?” Glimmer pointed out.

In their haste to escape, the four tumbled into a trench. The four looked around.

"Where are we?" Adora groaned.

Above them, the bug shrieked.

"No idea, but in there has to be better than out here!" Bow shouted, tugging the girls toward a doorlike structure. Bow tried to pry the doors apart to no avail.

"I'll teleport us!" Glimmer suggested.

"You can't teleport all four of us!" Bow objected. "You struggle with three people!"

"Do you have a better idea?!"

"Adora!" Catra yelped. "What does that writing say?"

It was not common knowledge that the royal ward could read the First Ones' language, but nor was it a well kept secret. After the initial shock of *Adora can read a dead language for no reason* wore off, Karma had Adora meeting with a few trusted scholars to help them decode the language, much to the young girl's delight.

“It’s-it’s like a password or something!” Adora stuttered.

“What does it *say* ?!”

“Uh- Eternia!” Adora yelled. The door’s runes glowed softly, before retracting into the surrounding structure.

“In!” Glimmer barked, shoving her friends into the ruin. The door shut behind them, leaving them in darkness.

Glimmer’s first glowed pink with magic, shedding some light in the dark room. “So…” she said, face illuminated by the sparkling ball of magic. “When did Catra propose?”

Catra groaned in frustration, banging her head against the wall. “Listen, idiots! As I said before, I was *four* .”

“What did you say?” Bow asked, amused.

“Can’t we talk about something else?” Catra sputtered, blushing wildly. “Like how we almost died?!”

“We’ve almost died before,” Glimmer dismissed. “I want to hear about baby Catra’s proposal.”

“She said, ‘if you were eight feet tall then I’d marry you’,” Adora relayed smugly.

“Can I be the best man?” Bow asked excitedly.

“Adora and I are *not* getting married!”

“Obviously, I’m the best man! I’m Catra’s sister!”

“So is Lonnie!”

“Bow, you can be my bridesmaid,” Adora offered.

“Great! I’ll start planning the wedding,” Bow gushed. “What do you want the wedding colors to be?”

“Nonexistent!”

“Red is both Adora and Catra’s color,” Glimmer said. “Purple wouldn’t look better either.”

“What about a nice royal blue?”

“ *Why don’t we find a way out* ?!” Catra almost shouted.

“Alright,” Bow agreed, beginning to walk down what appeared to be a hallway. “Adora, let’s talk details on the way. I’m thinking Catra will wear a suit, because let’s be honest, she’d rock that-“

“How about we just walk in silence?!”

It wasn’t long before they reached a cavernous room. After Glimmer expanded her light, they could see there was a large, impressive carving covering one wall, depicting a magnificent warrior.

“Oh hey! That’s you!” Bow said.

Adora frowned at him. “What are you talking about? That doesn’t look anything like me.”

“No, I mean, the other you. The scary one in the cape.”

“That was me?” Adora breathed, looking at the carving with new eyes.

“What’s that inscription say?” Catra asked, pointing.

Adora narrowed her eyes. “It says… She-Ra.”

Light swept across the carving, brightening the whole room. A hologram appeared, making them all shriek.

“Greetings, administrator,” it said in a slightly robotic tone.

“What in the moons?” Catra said.

“What is your query?”

“I think it’s some kind of ancient… hologram,” Bow said hesitatingly. “Hi. What is this place?”

The hologram stared blankly.

“How do we get out of here?”

No answer.

"Well, she's broken."

"Still pretty cool," Adora said, studying the figure. "I'm surprised she works at all."

Glimmer reached out to touch the hologram.

The hologram turned red. "Administrator not detected. Lockdown initiated."

The doors began to slam shut, one cracking halfway down.

"I didn't do it!" Glimmer squeaked, backing up.

"Obviously, Sparkles!" Catra tore her hands through her hair. "No lockdown!"

The chamber trembled, seeming unsettlingly close to collapsing. Bow let out an undignified yelp. "Adora, you gotta get it to stop!"

"What makes you think *I* can?!"

"Query not recognized."

"There's gotta be a password or something!" Catra said frantically.

"Stop it!" Adora yelled. "Eternia! Eternia!"

Eyes desperately raking the scene for a clue, Adora's gaze caught on She-Ra's sword. "I need the sword!"

"Scary lady in the cape?" Bow said.

"She does seem connected to this place," Catra muttered, shoving the sword into Adora's hands. "Do the thing."

"Uhm… for the honor of Grayskull!" Adora shouted, raising the sword.

With a flash of light, Adora was replaced by She-Ra. "Stop it!" she yelled, knocking a piece of falling debris aside.

The red tint vanished. “Administrator detected,” the hologram announced. “Welcome, She-Ra.”

“Phew,” Glimmer huffed. “That was… way too close.”

“How do we get out of here?” She-Ra asked, waving the sword in the hologram’s face.

“Query not recognized.”

“Is there an exit somewhere?”

“Query not recognized.”

“What is this sword?”

“Subject: The Sword of Protection. Classification: portable Runestone keyed exclusively to Administrator: She-Ra, Princess of Power.”

They all stared at the hologram. “Um… what?” Bow finally said.

“Let’s figure it out later,” Adora sighed, transforming back. “This is a dead end.”

Glimmer sighed. “I’ll just teleport us out one by one.”

“That does seem like the most reasonable option,” Bow agreed.

“Oh great,” Catra grumbled. “Teleporting. My favorite.”

“Quit complaining,” Glimmer ordered. “You’re going first, kitty cat.”

“Hey-“ Glimmer and Catra disappeared in a flash of pink sparkles.

The two girls found themselves about a dozen feet in the air. Thinking quickly, Catra’s feet shot out and she grabbed Glimmer, landing in a crouch.

Glimmer looked at her.

Catra looked at Glimmer. She was holding her in a bridal carry. “We will never speak of this again. I do not catch princesses.”

Glimmer couldn’t help herself. “You sure it’s not that you’d rather hang out with Adora?”

Catra regarded her flatly, then unceremoniously dropped her. Glimmer teleported back to the First Ones’ room, smirking.

“Bow next!”

. . .

“I see a village!” Bow announced.

“Great,” Catra said. “I can ditch you losers for civilization.”

“Don’t say that to your fiancée!” Glimmer chided, eyes sparkling with mischief.

“You are the *worst* .”

“That’s Thaymor, right?” Adora asked. “Don’t they have a festival this time of year?”

“Yeah,” Bow replied. “I’ve never been, but I’ve heard it’s fun.”

“We should go,” suggested Catra. “Before we get grounded for eternity.”

“I thought you said this would get us ungrounded?”

Catra shrugged. “Nah, I just wanted out of the house.”

“Figures,” Glimmer muttered. “Well, we’re going to be in trouble either way…”

“I vote we party,” said Adora.

“Yes!” Bow agreed, grinning. “Best Friends Squad party!”

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said. “I bet I can eat more fruit than you.”

Adora smirked, running towards the nearby booth. “Bring it on, kitty cat!” she called over her shoulder.

. . .

Force Captain Rosa studied the information in front of her, her critical eye dissecting the important details.

"That won't work," she announced, looking the senior Force Captain in the eye.

Octavia blinked. "What?"

"Or well, it *will* ," Rosa corrected herself. "Just not in the long term. You don't need all that firepower to take a civilian town. You'll end up damaging it, which lessens the point of taking it in the first place. The inhabitants will be angered and easier to stir up against the Horde."

"And what do you suggest we do, *oh wise one* ?" Octavia sneered.

"Simple," Rosa replied smoothly. "What we need is a firm show of force without being needlessly cruel. We don't want to wipe out the village when it could be a strategic position. We need to establish power over them by taking hostages- people of importance or perhaps children- and then incorporating them into the Horde."

Rosa paused, then smiled slyly at Octavia. "The trick is not to have the Horde be everywhere, it's to make everywhere the Horde."

. . .

Unlike every other Horde attack Catra had ever witnessed, the first sign of danger wasn't noise but the lack of.

Of their small group, she was the first to pick up on the eerie stillness. One moment, cheers and laughter bombarded her ears, making her feel as if she was swimming in sunlight. And then they tapered off, too quickly to be natural.

With her suspicions raised, Catra lifted an ear, trying to ascertain the cause for the sudden quiet.

And then she heard some speaking, hushed voices filled with worry. She couldn't make out most of the words, but one did catch her attention.

Horde .

Catra grabbed Adora's hand. "Come on, I need to check something out," she said briskly.

She crept up behind a house, peering at the crowd gathering in the center of the village. It wasn't hard to pick out the Horde soldiers.

“Go get Bow and Glimmer,” she hissed at Adora, jumping on top of the house to get a better view of the situation.

Not bothering to check if Adora was following her orders, she focused intently on the scene before her.

The apparent leader, an albino girl with calculating eyes, stood in front of four soldiers. Each soldier held a villager, stun baton touching their necks.

The albino girl spoke up. “Thaymor. We are emissaries of Lord Hordak. Thank you for your cooperation.

“We may appear heinous to you. I’m sure you’re aware of the horrific stories spread about the Horde and our brutal ways. But tell me, are your *princesses* any different?

“The princesses are given immense power and what do they do? Hole up inside their palaces and leave the common folk to fend for themselves. As if their magic entitles them to better treatment, safer lives.”

She spread her hands. “That is not the case with the Horde. Magic, that great and terrible advantage blindly given to the weak and petty, is used only with the greatest care. Blood does not

matter with the Horde. Hard work matters. We are equal. We protect each other.”

“You destroyed my village!” a middle aged man yelled. “Two-faced snake!”

“And did the princesses help you?” the girl rebutted. “Did they even *try* to save you? The fact is that there are two great powers in this world. The princesses, and the Horde. The first is too cowardly, too concerned for their own skins that they will not protect you. The second protects its own. You may choose which power to align yourself with, but only one will win in the end.”

“Bright Moon still fights!” the man argued.

“Bright Moon does not compare in size or power to the Horde. Alone, they will fall,” the albino stated frankly. “But I see your hesitation. To additionally motivate you to join the winning side, I have selected four of your people who will get to see the hospitality of the Horde up close.” She grinned, but there was no warmth in the smile. “Of course, in return for their safety, we expect you to accept Lord Hordak’s rule.”

“You’re blackmailing us?!” someone shouted.

“Blackmailing is a distasteful word,” the Horde girl said. “I prefer the term encourage.”

Catra growled, unable to stand another minute of the conniving, manipulative girl. She leapt in front of the crowd and faced the Horde girl.

"These people are innocent. Scram." Catra said coldly.

The girl smirked. "You are the princess Catra, I presume? I am Force Captain Rosa."

"I don't care what your name is. Get out of here."

Rosa opened her mouth to reply, but was cut off by the distinctive sound of Glimmer teleporting. She grabbed two of the hostages and teleported back, leaving the former captors dumbfounded. She swiftly repeated the action with the other two. Finally, she teleported herself and Bow next to Catra.

Rosa sighed. "Alright, fine. Plan B."

The order was relayed, and suddenly they were in the midst of a battle. It wasn't looking too great, especially since the three fighters were outnumbered ten to one.

And then *she* came.

The moment She-Ra arrived, it was like everything… stopped. It was entirely possible the Horde was just stunned by the random appearance of a giant lady, but to Catra, her arrival felt like peace, like safety.

...oh this *better* not be love.

Catra was thankfully distracted from *emotions* by Rosa shouting.

"Retreat!"

"What?!" a one-eyed Horde soldier protested.

"We're outmatched. Let's cut our losses," Rosa replied.

The Horde made a swift retreat, and they decided to forgo pursuing them because A) they couldn't really do anything even if they did catch them and B) they were a little more preoccupied with comforting the poor hostages.

The youngest of the hostages was a little girl with violet eyes, large deer like ears and horns, and dark brown skin. Deciding she was probably the least annoying of the four, Catra elected to talk to her.

“Hey,” she said. “I’m Catra. What’s your name?”

“Willow.”

“Hey, Willow. You were really brave today.”

Willow looked up at her, huge innocent eyes melting Catra’s heart. “Really?”

“Really,” Catra grinned. “Where’s your family?”

“Don’t have one,” Willow said matter-of-factly. “‘m in foster care.”

Catra stared at her. “So… are you up adoption then?”

. . .

“Catra no.”

“Catra *yes* .”

“Catra we cannot just adopt a child.”

“Look at her face Sparkles. Look at those eyes.”

“... you had better share the precious child.”

Chapter End Notes

I am fully aware this is not how adoption works, but Willow came in my head and refused to leave. So she’s here now, deal with it.
Sorry for the lack of a real fight scene. I hate writing them and will avoid it unless absolutely necessary.

Adora Loses Her Horse

Chapter Notes

> A lot of this episode had to be changed to fit this AU, and I'm fairly satisfied with the results.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"We made it!" Bow announced happily, nudging a dead tired Glimmer, who was clinging to him like a koala bear. She raised her head from his shoulder.

"Finally," she groaned.

"Whoa!" Willow gasped from her perch on Catra's shoulders.

"Welcome to Bright Moon!" Adora told the child, smiling brightly.

"It's really pretty!" Willow responded. "I get to live there?!"

"Yep," Catra said.

"Ok," Glimmer sighed. "How are we going to play this?"

“We have two things in our favor: She-Ra and Willow being adorable,” Catra replied. “That said, our moms would have a heart attack if we just strolled in with a random kid in tow.”

“We did protect Thaymor!” Adora added. “That’s gotta be worth something.”

“Nah, they’ll probably be more concerned with the whole putting ourselves in danger thing,” Catra argued.

“...I hate that you’re always right.”

. . .

“Children!” Angella shouted, wings spread wide. Beside her, Karma had her arms folded. “Where have you been?”

“Hey, Mom.” Adora mumbled.

“Your mom and I have been worried, kittens,” Karma said sternly. “I know you’re teenagers, but did you *really* have to up and vanish in the middle of the night? What exactly were you thinking?”

“Uh, Queen Karma-“ Bow began.

“Oh, lovely to see you Bow,” Angella interrupted. “But girls, what you did was selfish and disobedient-“

“Mom!” Catra shouted. “Glimmer needs to recharge. Like, now.”

Angella’s eyes widened. “Yes, of course,” she muttered, scooping her daughter up in her arms. She flew to the Moonstone, Glimmer cradled protectively.

Karma eyed them all. “I have a lot of questions for you all, including what you have a kid for, but first, I need to make sure Firecracker is okay. Understood?”

They all nodded, following the catlike woman to the Moonstone.

. . .

It seemed like hours before Glimmer blinked awake again. The whole family was sitting by her bedside, watching with concern.

“Are you all right?” Angella asked.

“I’m fine, Mom.” Glimmer said, sitting up.

Karma ruffled her hair. “Good to hear, kitten.”

“Don’t think you’re not still in trouble,” Angella said sternly, meeting each child’s eyes. “You didn’t even take the time to charge up- why is there an extra child?”

Catra hugged Willow protectively. “I adopted her.”

Angella buried her face in her hands, muttering something that sounded suspiciously like “dear moons it’s contagious”.

“Catra, sunshine…” Karma said. “Are you sure you’re ready to be a mom?”

“Yes,” Catra replied firmly. “And don’t act like this isn’t something you would do.”

Karma sighed, then grinned. “Angella, I do believe that makes us grandmothers.”

Willow wiggled out of Catra’s grasp, approaching Karma curiously. “Grandmothers?”

Karma picked Willow up and spun her around, making her giggle. She stopped, holding Willow up so their eyes met. “Yes. How’d you like to be my granddaughter?”

“That sounds good,” Willow agreed, curiously tugging on Karma’s ear.

“Great. You can call me Grandmama.”

Angella groaned. “Ok, back up. Where did you go, anyway?”

“Bow found this piece of super powerful First Ones’ tech in the woods,” Glimmer explained. “We knew it would help the Rebellion, so we went to get it and bring it back, but we got a little sidetracked and Catra got engaged to Adora.”

“I did not!” Catra objected, hair fluffing up in indignation. “That’s not what happened!”

“I found a magic sword that gives me powers,” Adora bragged simultaneously. “It makes me super buff.”

“I’m sorry, what?” Angella broke in. “Please explain more clearly.”

“Adora can turn into an eight foot tall warrior lady now,” Bow said.

“That… what?”

“Show them, Adora!”

“Uh...” Adora stuttered. “I don’t know if I can just turn on She-Ra, I’ve only done it when someone was in danger before. And it felt it felt a little out of control last time. I’m still figuring out how all this stuff works.”

“How hard can it be?” Glimmer argued. “Sword, magic words, poof!” She teleported into the air a few feet, landing gracefully. “She-Ra!”

“Okay…” Adora agreed reluctantly. “Ready to see something cool maybe? For the honor of Grayskull!”

Nothing happened.

“Adora…” Angella said, face returning to her hands.

Adora laughed nervously. “I’m gonna try that again. For the honor of Grayskull!”

There was still no reaction. Adora huffed, moving away to keep trying. Her attempts got progressively more ridiculous by the minute.

"Are you sure this isn't a strange idea you cooked up to try to get out of trouble?" Angella asked suspiciously.

Catra snorted. "Please, we might be able to lie to you, but we're not dumb enough to try it on Mama."

"I'm *sorry* ?" Angella sputtered, affronted.

"Yeah, Mama has a like bullcrap detector," Glimmer agreed. "All of us know better than to try to lie to her."

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora screamed nearby, and the sword emitted several golden beams. One almost hit Bow, who dodged, shrieking. Another smashed into the ceiling, leaving a scorch mark. A third sailed off the balcony.

"Adora!" Angella darted to her daughter's side. "Are you all right?"

"I think I hit Horsey…" Adora said dumbly, pointing at her horse.

The horse, who must have been grazing in the pasture below, was glowing brilliant gold. Two wings formed, and something on his head. The light faded, and Adora's horse was *very* colorful and clearly different.

"Oh my," Angella said faintly.

"Wait, didn't we read something about She-Ra?" Karma mused, eyeing the horse. "Seems like we should explore this."

Horsey studied himself, then neighed in panic and flailed into the army camp.

"Yeah…" Karma sighed. "Adora! Mother-daughter-in-law bonding trip, we're going to catch your horse and figure out your new sword." She placed Willow into Angella's arms. "And Ella, you and the kittens can help our new granddaughter settle in!"

. . .

"The new princess was unfairly strong," Victor complained. "Where do they even find those things? That one was like, twelve feet tall at least!"

"Her sword was pretty scary," Tina agreed timidly. "I can't imagine actually fighting her."

“Did you actually see her?” a dark haired cadet asked.

Tina nodded frantically. “She was huge! We were lucky to get out of there alive!”

“Not lucky,” Rosa corrected. “No such thing as luck. And yes, the new princess is strong. But she has a weakness.”

“How do you know?” Tina asked.

Rosa grinned, exposing her teeth. “No one is invincible. She may be powerful, but mark my words, she has exploitable weaknesses. Everyone does. The only reason we were in a bad situation was she caught us off guard. With proper planning I am sure we can take her out.”

. . .

By the time Karma and Adora reached the camp, the horse had already fled, leaving a trail of havoc in his wake.

“General Karma!” a panicked soldier shouted. “The horse-“

“We’re on it!” Karma called back, tugging Adora through the crowd. “Restore order! Hodge, you’re in charge until I get back!”

They dashed into the woods.

“See anything?” Karma asked as they paused for a break.

Adora shook her head. “No. Sorry Mama.”

Karma ruffled Adora’s hair. “Don’t be sorry, kitten. This is all very sudden. Of course you’re confused.”

“Thanks, mama-in-law,” Adora sighed, leaning against the older woman, who hugged her firmly.

A sudden noise made them freeze. “Horsey, is that you?” Adora called.

“Hm…” Karma hummed. “I don’t think so.” She pointed at a small hut where an old lady was emerging, humming as she swept the floor.

The old lady paused. “Did you hear something?” she hissed to the broom. “Yes, I did, too. Who’s there?”

Karma and Adora walked into the clearing in front of the hut.

"Hello," Karma said politely. "Sorry to intrude. We're looking for my daughter's horse."

"Yeah, have you seen a flying horse around here?" asked Adora.

The lady lifted her glasses and then placed them back again. "Oh, Mara, dearie, is that you?"

Adora nervously looked at Karma, who shrugged.

"About time you got here. Come on now, no time to waste. Let's get going." She walked back into her hut.

"I suppose it'd be rude to just leave…" Karma muttered, ducking into the house with Adora in tow. "You were waiting for us?"

The lady hopped around with surprising dexterity for her apparent age. "We made plans to go berry-picking today."

"I'm sorry, but I think you've mistaken us for someone else," Karma apologized. "We don't know who you are."

“No, you don’t know Madame Razz, do you?” the old lady said slowly. “You’re not quite the same. This is the wrong time for my Mara, isn’t it? Now you’ve got the sword instead.”

Adora and Karma exchanged glances. “What?”

“Well, never mind!” Razz laughed, putting a basket on Adora’s sword. “You’re here now and there’s berries to be picked.”

The two Bright Moon women trailed behind Razz, trying to question her.

“Hey, uh, you said something about the sword? Have you seen it before?” Adora tried, pushing through some bushes.

Razz chuckled. “Don’t ask such silly questions, Mara. You know you bring that sword around here all the time.”

“How long have you been living out here?” Karma asked.

“In the woods… alone.” Adora added.

“Alone? Me?” Razz laughed again. “Oh, no. I’m not alone. I’ve got Broom here, and my friend Loo-Kee too,” here she cupped a hand conspiratively around her mouth, “but he’s always hiding.”

“Are we sure we should be following her?” Adora whispered to Karma.

Karma paused up ahead. “Come look at this and I think you’ll have your answer.”

Adora obediently came up and saw a magnificent First Ones’ ruin, an elegant, overgrown castle. “Whoa.”

“Ah, here we are!”

“I’ve seen a place like this before,” Adora told Karma. “A huge First Ones’ ruin.”

Karma raised an eyebrow. “When?”

“When Bow, Catra, Glimmer, and I were out exploring,” Adora admitted. “It was pretty cool.”

“It’s the best place to pick fresh berries!” Razz told them, scampering up the side of the ruin.

“Be careful!” Adora shouted. “That doesn’t look safe!”

As Razz climbed the castle, lights began to shine from the ruin. When she reached a ledge, an outpour of light made her fall. Karma darted forward and snatched Razz from the air, landing lightly. “Careful there.” she said.

“Oh, dearie me. That was quite the tumble,” Razz chuckled, rubbing her head.

The three women looked around, their surroundings awash with iridescent light. A few lights in particular caught Adora’s eye.

“Stars?” Adora asked, eyes turned heavenward.

“Oh, we used to come here to look at the stars,” Razz reminisced fondly. “Do you remember, Mara? They’re all gone now. What happened to the stars?”

“Stars…” Karma repeated, brow furrowed. “Adora, where did you learn about stars?”

“I’ve seen them before,” Adora answered. “I know all of this, somehow.”

Adora got a faraway look in her eyes, then groaned. “What is this? What’s happening to me?”

Karma embraced the blond girl. “It’s okay, kitten,” she whispered, stroking her hair. “We’ll figure this out, and I’ll be with you every step of the way.”

Adora smiled slightly, leaning into the older woman’s touch. “Thanks, mama.”

Karma turned to Razz. “Miss, what do you know about Adora’s sword? Please, tell us.”

“I brought you here to pick berries, and your basket is still empty,” Razz replied. “So come on, silly.”

She grabbed Karma by the hand.

. . .

Angella frowned, taking in the documents in front of her. She sighed, pushing her work aside.

“Will you do the taxes for me, little one?” she teased her new granddaughter.

“Taxes are boring,” Willow argued, nose crinkling. “You should do something fun instead.”

Angella laughed. “Perhaps I should. What do you suggest?”

“Maybe you should do your hair,” Willow said, feet swinging merrily from her perch on Angella’s desk. “A braid would look kinda pretty.”

A gentle smile crossed Angella’s face. “All right then. How about you braid my hair while I-“

“Tell me a story?” Willow interrupted hopefully.

Angella settled on the ground in front of Willow. “What would you like to hear about?”

She felt a hand tug gently on her hair. “Um, do you know any stories about the moons?”

“I do,” Angella said. “Once, Naori, the kindest and most beautiful of the moons, fell in love with Khione, the eldest moon. Khione,

however, was cold and distant and was said to have no room in her heart for any.”

She smiled as Willow’s tiny hands wove through her hair.

“Khione would not believe Naori truly loved her, and did not listen to her pleas. Naori, heartbroken, cried onto Etheria, filling the oceans. Finally Naori arose and decided to prove her devotion to Khione. She scooped up her tears and held them close to her heart, and they hardened into the most beautiful jewel anyone had ever set eyes on. She gave it to Khione, who felt her heart melt.”

“Why?” Willow asked innocently.

“Maybe she really liked jewels,” answered Angella. “The two moons embraced, and ever since then, no one has seen the two apart. They placed the jewel on Etheria as a symbol of their love, where it became known as the Moonstone.”

“Whoa,” Willow gasped. “I got to see that!”

“Yes, you did,” Angella replied fondly. “It’s a wonderful story, isn’t it?”

Willow walked around her and snuggled into her lap. “It’s nice. I like it.”

Angella caught her reflection in the mirror. She now sported perhaps the worst braid she'd ever seen.

It was beautiful.

"I like it too."

. . .

Rosa expected to feel fear when Shadow Weaver came to berate her for her failure.

Instead she felt mild annoyance.

"Rosa. You failed."

Rosa shook her head. "Failure was unavoidable with incorrect intel. The princesses were a variable we did not take into account. The new one is a new factor entirely."

Shadow Weaver towered over her. "I gave you a simple task- take Thaymor. Instead, your squadron was ravaged and the Horde has nothing to show for its efforts."

“On the contrary,” Rosa replied calmly. “We are now aware of a threat we can now endeavor to contain. With further study, this new princess can be neutralized.”

“I am not interested in your excuses,” Shadow Weaver thundered, shadows wrapping around the albino girl as the older woman spoke. “You will answer to Lord Hordak himself.”

. . .

“Wait! Will you slow down?” Adora panted, trailing behind Karma and Razz. Karma glanced over at her and scooped the blonde up, ignoring Adora’s noises of protest.

“Ma *ma* ,” Adora whined.

“Do you want a break or not?” Karma replied, amusement coloring her tone.

“Fiiiiine.”

Karma suddenly stopped, sniffing the air.

“Mama?” said Adora.

“The Horde’s here,” Karma said timelessly, walking into a clearing. Horde tanks littered the ground among charred stumps, the once healthy forest a tangible ghost.

“Ah, it’s the same old story, dearie.” Madame Razz sighed. “Wicked people destroy what they cannot control.”

“They can’t just do this!” Adora protested, sounding close to tears. Karma pulled her daughter close.

“Once, the princesses would have protected us… now they protect only their own lands. Meanwhile, the Horde creeps ever closer.” For the first time since they’d met her, Madame Razz did not exude boundless energy; instead, her age truly showed in her careworn voice. “You’re very like my Mara, you know. Brave, loyal, but afraid.”

“I’m not afraid,” Adora denied.

Karma lightly swatted her nose. “Everyone’s afraid sometimes, kitten. I’m scared often.”

“You?” Adora whispered, sounding very young.

“Yes,” Karma whispered back. “I’m very scared I might lose one of my children or Angella.”

Razz chuckled. “It’s okay to be afraid. You know right from wrong. You can figure out what you should do.”

Adora blinked. “I think… this is wrong.”

A horse’s neigh split the air. Adora and Karma jolted, looking towards the sound. “Horsey!”

Five Horde soldiers surrounded the transfigured Horsey, two holding ropes looped around his neck. The other three threw ropes as well, making the horse firmly in their grasp. Horsey snapped through the ropes, but they tossed a net onto him, sending him to the ground.

Karma looked at Adora. “Kitten, do you think you could use your magic sword?”

Adora looked at her reflection in the sword. Her eyes hardened. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Karma watched in awe as Adora grew in size and transformed before her eyes. “That’s… new,” she said. “Now c’mon, kitten, we have to rescue your pet.”

They jumped down into the Horde camp, She-Ra slicing neatly through the net. Karma roundhouse kicked a soldier.

"Turn off your machines and leave this place, now!" She-Ra shouted. Karma grinned proudly.

"It's one of the queens and the new princess! Get them!" a Force Captain shouted.

She-Ra swished her sword, making the ground rise up and throw most of the soldiers off balance. Karma jumped from soldier to soldier, making them drop like stones.

She-Ra jumped onto a tank and chopped the barrel off. She threw the barrel onto another tank and then threw her sword at another. She turned to the Force Captain, who ran to the door, which opened to release a fresh batch of soldiers.

A brawl broke out, She-Ra and Karma outnumbered but not outmatched. Razz cheered from the trees, "That's my girl!" Razz threw She-Ra the sword, shouting her name, who caught it deftly. Horsey trampled a Horde soldier and flew off. The Force Captain aimed a cannon at Horsey. She-Ra spotted this, and chopped the barrel in half. Smirking, the captain fired anyways, catching She-Ra in the chest. She flew backwards twenty feet.

Karma roared. She tackled the Force Captain and hoisted him by his ankles, then threw him as far as she could. She then ran over to She-Ra. “Kitten!”

Soldiers were beginning to surround them. Karma bared her fangs. “Who else hurt my kitten?! Who wants to die?!”

Razz tossed something on the ground, shouting “Razzle dazzle!”. The ensuing flash was bright enough to blind the soldiers. Karma grabbed Razz and She-Ra and leapt out of the camp.

When Adora awoke, three faces were hovering over her: Karma, Horsey, and Razz.

“Hello, dearie,” Razz said.

“Welcome back, kitten,” Karma brushed some hair out of Adora’s eyes.

Adora groaned, clutching at her chest. “Ow.”

“Gave me quite the scare there, daughter-in-law,” Karma said. “Also, the horse is different than I remember.”

“Swift Wind has been talking to us while you were asleep,” Razz added helpfully. “He thanks you for coming to his rescue.”

“Swift Wind?”

“That’s what he prefers to be called. Also, he wanted to make sure that you know that ‘Horsey’ was a stupid name. How do you feel?”

“Okay,” Adora answered. “I think I have a better handle on this.”

Karma squeezed Adora’s shoulder. “You did great, kitten. I think you’re ready to defend Etheria.”

“Really?”

“With parental supervision.”

“Ah man.”

“It was lovely to meet you, Madame Razz,” Karma told the diminutive woman. “Would it be all right if we visited you again sometime?”

"If you need me, you always know where to find me," Razz responded, going into her house.

Karma smiled at Adora. "Ready to go back to Bright Moon?"

"We *did* find Hors-I mean, Swift Wind," Adora agreed. "Speaking of which-" she turned to the horse, "-can we get a ride back to Bright Moon? Please?"

. . .

She-Ra and Karma walked into the Bright Moon kitchen to find Kyle frosting a cake while Bow, Catra, Glimmer, Rogelio, Willow and Angella played a card game.

"You got it to work!" Glimmer cheered, hugging She-Ra. She detransformed, setting the sword aside to embrace Glimmer.

"I'm proud of you, sweetheart," Angella said. "...you're still in trouble, though."

. . .

Shadow Weaver dragged an impassive Rosa through a dimly lit laboratory. "Lord Hordak," she said.

Hordak turned. Rosa knelt.

"I gave her charge of a simple mission: to sack Thaymor. Instead, our forces suffered a humiliating defeat."

"The new princess was an unexpected variable," Rosa insisted. "Thaymor is, strategically speaking, not of great importance in any case. It would be better to strike at Salineas and choke off supplies."

Hordak raised an eyebrow. "This one is cunning." He grinned. "I like her."

Chapter End Notes

> Does Karma know Swift Wind can speak now? Yes. Is she going to warn anyone? Absolutely not. She is planning to use their reactions as blackmail to get them to clean their rooms.

The Hippies Attempt To Ignore The Fact The World Sucks

Chapter Notes

> This is kinda short, but whatever. All my knowledge of strategy comes from reading an unhealthy amount of fantasy and about a chapter of the Art of War.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Okay. You've seen the dining hall, the throne room, the portrait hall, Mom's office," Glimmer said excitedly, Willow perched on her shoulders. Beside her, Catra watched Glimmer carefully, ready to catch the child should she slip. "So, the last stop on our grand tour is your new room! Ta-da!"

Willow gasped. "All this is for me?"

"Yup!" Catra replied.

"It's pretty standard, but nice enough for a princess!" Glimmer told Willow. "You got your vanity, bathroom, crystals, bell pull, tea nook, more crystals, bed, desk, and of course, the waterfall."

Willow's eyes were round. "It's so sparkly n' pretty! Like you, Glimmer!"

Glimmer squealed, lifting Willow off her shoulders and tossing her into the air. Willow giggled wildly, landing safely in Glimmer's waiting arms.

"Hey!" Catra barked. "Careful!"

"'m okay!" Willow protested. "See?" She spread her arms, pouting at Catra.

Catra softened. "Sorry sweetie. I was just worried Sparkles would drop you."

"I would never!" Glimmer protested. "You, on the other hand-"

"Hey!" Catra shrieked.

Glimmer laughed. "Okay Willy, we're right down the hall if you need anything."

"Goodnight sweetheart," Catra said, kissing Willow's forehead and carrying her to her new bed.

Willow hugged Catra. "G'night, Catra."

. . .

Willow jolted awake.

She lay there for several seconds. In the seconds it took to remember where she was, Willow had forgotten what exactly had woken her up, but she knew she'd had a nightmare.

Willow tossed and turned for a few more minutes, before deciding to see if Catra or Glimmer were awake. She slipped out the doors, stumbling blearily down the hallway.

"Glimmer?" she whispered. "Catra?"

She almost ran into a hulking figure. Willow let out a quiet whimper, before recognizing the person as Rogelio, Catra and Glimmer's brother.

"Ro'lio?" she said, stumbling over the name.

The lizard man seemed to smile. His hands waved around in complex patterns.

"Um, that's you talking, right?" Willow said shyly. "I dunno any sigh language…"

Rogelio seemed to laugh, then signed something.

Willow suddenly perked up. “D’you think you could teach me? Like, I ask you what a word is, and you sign it for me?”

Rogelio gave her a thumbs up.

Willow beamed. “Great! Come see my room, it’s really cool!”

. . .

“Hey, sleepyhead,” Glimmer cooed, edging Willow’s door open. “Wake u- huh. That was not what I was expecting.”

“What? What’s wrong?” Catra snapped, shoving past Glimmer. “Oh.”

Rogelio and Willow were snuggled up on her bed, the former curled protectively around the smaller person.

“All right, that’s super cute,” Adora announced.

“Should we just… leave them?” Bow asked.

The teens looked at each other, before quietly closing the door. “Weekly meeting!” Catra cheered quietly. “How much do you want to bet Mom doesn’t want us to fight?”

“That’s not a bet, that’s robbery,” Glimmer argued. “Mom *never* wants to fight.”

Adora snorted, pushing the War Room’s doors. “Spinnerella and Netossa! Hey guys!”

The couple waved.

Angella and Karma took their seats, side by side. As always, Karma took a moment before she sat down, in honor of her predecessor.

“We have asked you here today because I received a distress call from Princess Perfuma. The Horde is laying siege to her kingdom. She’s asking Bright Moon for assistance. Karma?”

“Plumeria is located near the front lines. The Horde has set up camp in her territory, cutting off their main supply route.”

“Doesn’t Plumeria produce most of their own food?” Catra asked. “Pretty sure they’re called the breadbasket kingdom for a reason.”

Karma flashed Catra a proud smile. “Good observation, Catra. Recently, their crops have been seriously damaged. They’ve entered a famine.”

“Bright Moon will provide food and humanitarian aid,” Angella declared.

“Ooh! Ooh!” Glimmer said. “I have a better idea! We could-“

“-fight the Horde?” Angella finished wearily. “Glimmer, you propose this idea every meeting.”

“No! I was gonna say…” Glimmer hesitated. “...let’s use aggressive fist-to-face sparkles?”

“I said *no* Glimmer. Now sit down.”

Karma sighed. “As much as I hate the Horde, we can’t fight them in Plumeria. Officially speaking, Plumeria is neutral. We cannot start fights in other kingdoms, even if we’re helping them.” She frowned, then muttered under her breath. “Idiotic politicians.”

“Thanks,” Angella said dryly.

“You should send me, Glimmer, Bow, and Catra to lead the relief mission. I can go as She-Ra. I’ll make sure everyone gets there safely and protect them if the Horde attacks.” Adora suggested. “We can try to prove we can be responsible to you.”

Karma and Angella exchanged glances. Angella sighed. “Very well. You will deliver food and supplies to Plumeria. And under *no circumstances* will you engage the Horde.”

“You can leave at dawn,” Karma added. “Get Kyle to pack you some sandwiches.”

. . .

“So,” Shadow Weaver said, her voice dripping with disdain. “You have a plan to invade Salineas?”

“Correct,” Rosa calmly responded. “The best way to win a war is to cut off your enemy’s basic needs. Food, water, sleep, and shelter. Without any one of these, the populace grows restless. The ruler must expend more resources to quell their own people. They are more easily turned, less loyal to the upper class.”

“And this has *what* to do with Salineas?”

“Salineas is a major port,” Rosa explained, “Their capital especially. If we manage to capture that, we choke off trade and cause a severe economic crisis.”

Shadow Weaver hummed thoughtfully. “Not a bad idea. How do you plan to get past the Sea Gate?”

“Dark magic.”

“Dark- *what* ?” Shadow Weaver sputtered. “You don’t know magic!”

“Yet,” Rosa corrected. “You are going to teach me.”

. . .

“Wow,” Catra said. “When Mama said damaged, I didn’t realize she meant literally everything was dying.”

“I don’t think she knows,” Glimmer replied.

“Where did Adora go?” Bow asked. “I need to get her opinion on catering for the wedding.”

“Bow, do you want me to kill you?”

She-Ra caused a slight diversion by hoisting the cart over her head while climbing over a tree root.

“Are you going to be She-Ra the entire time we’re here?” Glimmer inquired.

“Yeah, this is gonna get old,” agreed Catra.

“I told Mom I would,” She-Ra chuckled. “Besides, I’m way cooler as She-Ra. Could Adora do this?” She started using the cart as a weight.

“Yeah, that’s very useful to our mission,” Glimmer deadpanned.

“Does your hair poof compensate for a lack of brains?” Catra snarked.

“Hey, guys?” Bow interrupted. “Does anyone know what that is?” He pointed to a cloud of smoke.

“Must be coming from the Horde camp,” She-Ra concluded.

“You’re here!” a blond woman shouted.

Glimmer smiled, stretching out her hand. “Princess Perfuma. I’m Commander Glimmer.”

Flowers appeared in Glimmer’s hand. Then wreaths of flowers materialized on Bow and Catra’s heads.

“I get a hat?” Bow asked, delighted, while Catra hissed. “Hey! Warn me next time!”

Perfuma, having spotted She-Ra, ignored them. “Oh, my,” she said. “Everyone, come quick! It’s… oh, it’s… it’s...Look! The universe has heard our pleas and sent the legendary She-Ra to help us save our home!”

She-Ra set the cart aside and cleared her throat. “We’ve heard about the blockade and we’ve come to help. We’ve brought food and supplies for you.”

“Welcome to Plumeria, She-Ra,” Perfuma said. The Plumerians crowded She-Ra, a baby somehow ending up on her arm.

“Catra!” She-Ra hissed. “What do I do?”

Catra smirked. “Why are you asking me?”

“Cause I thought you would *help me* ?”

“...nah, I like watching you suffer.”

“Come with me, I’ll show you around. You’re gonna love it.”

Perfuma began to show them around. “Our people have lived here in tranquility for thousands of years. We’re known for a beautiful flowers, our majestic trees.” She stopped in front of a huge tree with a large pink gemstone set in the trunk. “And this is the Heart-Blossom, the center of our kingdom, and the source of all my magical powers.”

“At least this tree is fine,” Catra muttered. “For now, at least.”

“What happened to everything else?” Bow wondered.

Perfuma slumped slightly. “We’re going through a little rough patch, but I’m sure the universe will right itself soon.”

“Everything is dead or dying.” Catra said flatly. “That’s not a rough patch. That’s a problem.”

“Look, the blight hit right after the Horde arrived. We don’t know why, and nothing I do stops it. But we don’t dwell on the negative. Look at the positive. The Heart-Blossom is still healthy, and the She-are is here, and the celebration is about to begin!”

Perfuma tossed flowers onto She-Ra, who blinked.
“...celebration?”

. . .

She-Ra sat surrounded by adoring people trying to give her free food.

It was horrible.

“No, it’s okay, you need the food more than we do,” she tried to say.

A woman holding a bowl waved her off. “It is an honor to serve the She-Ra!”

Catra huffed, and pushed through the crowd. “Yep, okay, thanks. I’m going to need to talk to the She-Ra alone now.”

She dragged She-Ra some distance away, then motioned Bow and Glimmer over. “Okay guys,” she said. “I’ve just about had it with hippie land. They have serious problems.”

“I think it’s kind of nice,” Bow argued, scratching his neck.

Catra snorted. “Look. You know me. You know I don’t like depending on luck or the universe to solve my problems. These people are just expecting She-Ra to fix everything.”

“Yeah…” She-Ra agreed. “I mean, I can try to heal the trees and stuff. How hard can it be?”

Catra shot her a flat look. “Adora, last time you tried to wing this whole She-Ra thing you transformed your horse.”

“...fair point.”

“It’s obvious the Horde is causing the blight,” Catra continued. “You have no idea how to use your magic, but we can take out a Horde base.”

“Um… didn’t Queen Angella give us strict instructions to *not* fight the Horde?” Bow pointed out.

Catra waved a hand. “That was for two reasons. One, so we don’t cause a diplomatic incident by attacking without Plumeria’s support. We’ll need that anyways; our best course of action is to convince Flowers over there.”

“...and the second?”

“Mom doesn’t want us to get hurt. But we ignore that issue all the time, so…”

“I don’t know…” She-Ra replied. “Isn’t this trip a way to earn trust back? Should we really disregard orders like that?”

Catra groaned, then sighed. “Let me put it this way. Currently, the prominent agricultural kingdom is experiencing a famine caused by the Horde. Their princess is doing nothing to try to stop the cause, instead is ineffectually treating the symptoms. If we want to save Plumeria and consequently thousands from starvation, we need to remove whatever the Horde are doing to make the land sick, and we need to do it in a joint effort with Plumeria.”

The other three blinked at her. “Well, when you say it like that…” Glimmer responded. “Yeah, I’ll go get Perfuma.”

. . .

"You want us to *fight* ?" Disbelief colored Perfuma's tone.

"Yes." Catra replied firmly.

"Wouldn't it be easier to just have the She-Ra heal our land?" Perfuma said hopefully.

Adora dropped her transformation. "Princess Perfuma, my name is Adora. I was chosen to carry the sword of She-Ra. But I'm still new to this. I don't know how to heal yet."

Perfuma gasped. "Then… then we have to leave."

"What?" Bow blurted.

"If She-Ra can't save us, no one can!"

"Bull." Catra cut in, "You are fully capable of saving yourselves."

"But… all I do is make flowers!" Perfuma argued. "We can't fight! We aren't strong enough!"

“I disagree,” Catra said. “You can’t just wait around for the universe to make things better. Sometimes you need to be the one to make the difference.”

Perfuma considered. “That’s very insightful.”

“Thanks.”

“This is our home,” Perfuma decided, resolve entering her eyes. She raised her voice. “Everyone, She-Ra and our friends from Bright Moon are willing to risk their lives to protect us from the Horde. We need to help them save our kingdom! Get the warchimes and let’s march!”

“Shouldn’t we make a plan?” Bow wondered.

Catra shook her head. “Pretty sure they won’t be expecting a full on frontal assault. We got this.”

About ten minutes later they were riding a wave of vines into the Horde camp, destroying Horde property left and right. It was a fairly easy fight- the Horde was caught off guard and was not really trained to defend themselves against assault via shrubbery. She-Ra was quick to discover and neutralize the Horde’s devise responsible for poisoning the land, and the soldiers were chased off after a few minutes of being pummeled by vegetation.

“Well, that was fun,” Catra said, wiping sweat off her brow. “Not bad, Flowers.”

“Thank you, Catra!” Perfuma replied. “You inspired us to save ourselves. How can we ever thank you?”

“Join the Rebellion, and help me reform the Princess Alliance,” Glimmer answered.

“Um, are you sure? Didn’t that go horribly the first time?”

“Well, is fighting on our own going much better?” Catra observed wryly. “We’re losing ground every day.”

“We’re clearly stronger together,” Glimmer agreed. “Think of what all the Princesses United could do.”

“Would I… get to hit more people with flowers?” Perfuma inquired hesitantly.

“Absolutely.” Glimmer grinned.

“You have a deal,” Perfuma replied. “Hey, look everyone! We’re mighty rebels now!”

. . .

“So you mean to tell me you disobeyed orders- *again* - and engaged the Horde- *again* .” Angella stated flatly.

“No, no,” Catra disagreed. “I mean to tell you that we saved Plumeria and successfully convinced them to join the Rebellion. And, okay, yeah, disobeyed orders. Again.”

“Honestly this turned out exactly how I expected,” Karma sighed. “Good job, kittens. You’re grounded for a week. Let’s go eat celebratory cake.”

Chapter End Notes

> Again, this one’s kinda short. I think it’s because I don’t think Adora would be as insecure because she didn’t just defect and she’s not dealing with prejudice, and also Catra isn’t going to put up with the hippies any longer than she has to. Unrelated, I think if Karma were able to transform into She-Ra, the Horde would be so dead. She’d march into the Fright Zone and beat Hordak using Shadow Weaver as a club.

Explosions Now Included

Chapter Notes

Scorpia arrives!!
Not going to lie, she is my favorite character.
I almost had Karma take her too, but... Princess Prom.
The actual plot in this is short. Most of this is enough fluff to suffocate on.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Fo' the power-"

"Honor," Adora corrected.

Willow nodded, then continued, "-honor of Grayskull!"

Rogelio picked her up and sat her on his shoulders. Willow hugged his head with one hand, and held a stick aloft with the other. "I am the mighty princess She-Ra, and I'm gonna defeat the Horde!"

"Not if *I* have anything to say about it," Catra said dramatically. She flipped her hair, smirking playfully at Willow. "I have the *purr* fectly evil plan to defeat She-Ra."

"You're punning?" Bow asked, surprised.

“I’m a villain. There is *nothing* more evil than puns.”

“Disagreed!”

“...did you seriously just say *disagreed* ?”

“People say ‘agreed’ when the agree, so it makes sense.”

“Bow!” Willow shouted. “You wanna be on my team or Catra’s?”

“Yours,” Bow said immediately. “I can’t work with anyone who hates the highest form of comedy!”

Willow grinned. “You can be a general! Like Grandmama!”

“General Bow has a nice ring to it,” said Bow appreciatively.

“Ro‘lio and me are She-Ra, Catra is Force Captain, Adora’s her sidekick-“

“I am not a sidekick!”

Catra glared at Adora. “I’m sorry, are you insinuating that Willow is wrong?”

Adora gulped. “Uh… never mind. Do I at least get paid?”

“No. That’s not how we do things around here,” Catra replied. “You can be my henchman.”

“I do *not* hench.”

“Shut it, henchman.”

Kyle interrupted Adora and Catra’s bantering. “What about me?”

“You’re my chef,” Willow decided. “You make me cookies and sweets.”

“Sounds good to me!”

Catra cleared her throat, tail swishing flamboyantly. “She-Ra, *purr* pare to meet your *claw* ful end!”

“No!” Willow squealed. She swished her stick vaguely in Catra’s direction.

Catra immediately shoved Adora in front of her. “Minion, take the princess’s fire!”

For a moment, Adora just stood there. Then- with a sharp elbow from Catra- Adora began to slowly sink down. “Oh no. I am… dying… from sword wounds? Wounds from a sword. Yeah, that’s what’s happening.”

Behind Willow, Kyle facepalmed.

“Yay!” said Willow. “Now I just have defeat the Force Captain!”

“Im *paw* sible,” Catra purred. “As in *fur* iating as you are, your *cat* titude will get you nowhere.”

“She-Ra, may I suggest a plan?” Kyle said.

“Mm-hm!” Willow hummed.

Kyle pulled Rogelio aside, then carefully handed Willow an object. “What you hold is the most effective weapon against Force Captain Catra,” he told her solemnly. “One hit and she’s done for.”

“What are you giving her?” Catra asked suspiciously.

“Hurry,” Kyle said in a stage whisper.

Rogelio turned back to Catra, smirking, and Willow wasted no time spraying Catra with the squirt bottle Kyle had given her.

Catra shrieked, hair standing on end. “What the- betrayal! *Why* , Kyle?!”

She stood there, soaking wet, as everyone burst out laughing. Against her will, a smile began to form before she squished it. “You guys are the worst.”

“Hey guys!” Glimmer said, sticking her head in Willow’s room. “Uh… why is Catra soaking wet?”

“Because my family is awful,” Catra sulked. “What do you need, Sparkles?”

“It’s meeting time,” Glimmer replied. “Also, next time we’re having playtime, invite me, will you?”

. . .

"Counsel, we're looking for plans to strengthen our defenses against the Horde. Who would like to go first?" Angella said.

Glimmer's hand shot up. Angella sighed. "Who *besides* Glimmer would like to go first?"

Karma stood up. "We've heard chatter from the Horde. Seems like they're planning a strike on Salineas."

"Perfect!" Glimmer blurted.

Everyone turned to her, faces incredulous. She blushed, but continued. "It's a good opportunity to recruit Princess Mermista. If we can form a new Princess Alliance, the Rebellion might actually stand a chance for once."

Karma raised an eyebrow. "You're forgetting something. We can't just start fights on other kingdoms' territory."

"Which is why you should send a few of us on a *diplomatic* mission to convince them to let us help," Glimmer insisted. "We *need* Salineas. Anyone approaching Bright Moon by sea would have to go through the Sea Gate. If Salineas falls, Bright Moon would be fighting on two fronts."

Karma nodded slowly. “Your suggestion has its merits. It would be dangerous, though.”

“Don’t worry, Mama,” Glimmer replied. “With She-Ra, we can conquer anything.”

“And a boat,” Catra pointed out. “And without me. I don’t do boats.”

Glimmer huffed. “Fine. With She-Ra, a boat, and no Catra, we can STILL conquer anything.”

“None of us know how to sail,” Catra said flatly.

Glimmer gritted her teeth. “With She-Ra, a boat, *and* an experienced sea captain, we can conquer anything.”

Angella and Karma exchanged glances, before nodding. “Fine,” Angella said. “Glimmer, Adora, Bow, and Kyle will go to Salineas.”

“Why me?” Kyle questioned.

“You’re their impulse control,” Angella informed him wearily. “Good luck.”

. . .

“This is so cool,” Bow squealed, beaming. “Seaworthy looks just like I imagined it. Everyone here looks like a real pirate!”

“Focus, Bow,” Glimmer reprimanded. “We’re just here to find a sea captain.”

“Preferably one with a boat,” Kyle muttered.

“No pirates?”

“No pirates.”

Bow drooped sadly.

Glimmer walked up to the bar. “Excuse me, we’re looking for a captain to take us to Salineas.”

The bartender pointed out a man, surrounded by a cluster of boisterous people. He was arm wrestling someone, who he promptly beat. "Drinks all around! On my friend here's tab!" he announced, grinning victoriously.

"Uh… hi," Glimmer ventured. "We were told you're a sea captain?"

"I am the one and only Sea Hawk," he replied, jumping on the table. "Has my reputation preceded me?"

"Your name is Sea Hawk? That's the coolest name I've ever heard," Bow gushed.

Glimmer rolled her eyes and stepped forward. "Captain Sea Hawk? We're interviewing potential captains to take us to Salineas. Would you like to apply for the position?"

Sea Hawk laughed. "Apply for the position?" he repeated. "I am the one and only Sea Hawk. I'm offer only."

"Okay," Adora said skeptically. "Just because 'sea' is in your name? It doesn't tell us anything about your actual qualifications."

"Qualifications? I once ran the 50-klick Galebreath Gauntlet in less than twenty klicks. I maneuvered the Serpentine with nary a chip in the paint of my bow. My shanties are considered so desirable that sirens fling themselves into the sea at the sound of them." He

leaned forward, smirking. “And because I can tell you’re wondering, my mustache is naturally shiny.”

“It *is* shiny. You’re hired!” Bow declared, receiving an elbow from Glimmer. “Ow!”

“Whoa there, kids! What makes you think you can afford me?”

“We’re rich,” Kyle deadpanned. “Money isn’t usually an issue.”

“Behold my fee,” Sea Hawk said, sliding a paper over.

Glimmer took one glance at it and winced. “Money may be an issue. You know what? Fine. We’ll find another sea captain.”

“Good luck with that. You won’t find another soul who knows the treacherous route to Salineas as well as I do. I brave it often to visit my close personal friend, Princess Mermista.”

“You know her?”

“ *Do* I!”

"Then you'll want to help us," Kyle said. "The Horde are moving on her kingdom. We're going to offer Bright Moon's aid in repelling them."

Sea Hawk considered. "That *does* sound exciting. A daring attempt to fend off the horrid beasts? A hero's quest? I'm in. Free of charge."

"Really?" Kyle responded, surprised.

"Of course. ADVENTURE!"

. . .

Rosa studied the woman in front of her. Tall and obviously strong, Force Captain Scorpia cut quite an imposing figure. Up until she spoke, that was. She didn't seem very intelligent, but she *was* loyal. Rosa could use that.

"Scorpia," she said, sticking out her hand. "I am Rosa. Are you ready to sack Salineas?"

Scorpia beamed, grabbing her hand in her pincer and shaking it rapidly. Rosa hissed in pain. *I suppose I should've thought of that…* She yanked her hand back, smiling politely.

“I’m so excited!” Scorpia declared. “I love boats, don’t you?”

“They’re very useful,” Rosa replied absently.

“But don’t you love the wind in your hair and the endless expanse of sea?”

Rosa raised an eyebrow. “That seems a trivial thing to be concerned about. Boats are a means to an end. Nothing more.”

“I disagree,” Scorpia responded. “Whenever I’m on one, I feel like I’m flying!”

Rosa forced herself to keep smiling blandly. “Please maintain your enthusiasm for the fight.”

. . .

Six arguments, nine arm wrestles, a few shanties and a boat ride later, the five of them arrived at Salineas. The port was deserted, a hollow shell of the usually humming throb of *life* it used to emit.

They managed to talk their way past the guard (singular guard?!) and gain an audience with Princess Mermista.

As soon as the doors opened, Glimmer marched in and started speaking. “Hello Princess Mermista. I’m Glimmer of Bright Moon and I’m here with an offer.”

Mermista looked at her, feigning boredom. “If you haven’t noticed, the kingdom’s kind of falling apart.”

“We can help,” Glimmer said firmly. “Our mother General Karma is bringing Bright Moon’s army as we speak to the border. With your permission, we can help you fight off the Horde.”

Mermista snorted. “The Sea Gate will fall within a day or two. Your army won’t get here in time.”

“Hey,” Adora interrupted. “Were you aware that these windows tell you how the Sea Gate works?”

“No,” Mermista drawled. “Nice to know before they get destroyed.”

“No, listen. The First Ones must have built the Sea Gate. It looks like the Gate gets its power from the Salinean Runestone... It could be that the Gate is failing because it's losing its connection to the power source.”

“Think you could fix it?” Glimmer said hopefully.

Adora shrugged. “I can try…”

“Great,” Kyle said. “Adora, try to fix the gate. Bow, defend her. Guard person, please send a message to General Karma. Everyone else, we need to slow the Horde down. Any ideas?”

“Set their ships on fire!” Sea Hawk suggested.

“Ughhhhh,” groaned Mermista. “Your plans are the worst. Why did you *bring* him here? He is *so* annoying.”

Glimmer started, a grin forming on her face. “Actually… it’s not a bad idea. Where do you keep your explosives?”

. . .

Tina squinted, dazzled by the sparkling gate. It was nothing like the Fright Zone, beautiful and delicate and *alive* .

And they were here to destroy it.

But it had to be done! They had to protect Etheria from princesses!

...like the one who just teleported on board with a bunch of explosives.

Crap .

Not for the first time, she wondered why she even signed up for the Horde. ~~She didn't. She was kidnapped.~~

Tina had enough presence of mind to jump off the boat before it blew up.

. . .

After a few hours of Glimmer teleporting bombs onto the Horde ships, thinning them out, She-Ra managed to fix the gate. The princesses and their friends retired for the night, the ~~overworked~~ guard promising to keep watch.

The next morning they were roused by the guard's excited shouts. They rushed over to see the Bright Moon army marching into the city.

"Wow," Mermista said. "They actually made it."

“Yeah,” Glimmer smiled. “They did. Mermista, would you consider joining the new Princess Alliance?”

“Wasn’t the first one a total disaster?”

“Worth a shot though, right?” Kyle said. “Plus, we have She-Ra.”

“Yeah, I’d like the eight foot tall lady on my side,” Mermista agreed. “Whatever. I’m in.”

“Me too!” Sea Hawk declared. “I will help the Rebellion on their noble quest. ADVENTURE!”

Kyle grinned. “We need more boys in the group. Welcome to the Rebellion.”

“... how much trouble do you think we’re in for fighting the Horde?”

“At this point I think our moms have come to expect it.”

Chapter End Notes

Yeah, the Horde is still there. The siege is going to go on longer in this AU... and will have different results.
Also, GET MERMISTA’S GUARD A RAISE! Literally everyone else left, and he’s doing all the work?! This guy deserves

appreciation.
Some of you may be wondering “what’s Rosa’s deal?” Is she after power like Shadow Weaver? Trying to prove herself like the original Catra? Something else entirely?
She has her reasons. Eventually you’ll get to learn them.

Alexa And Siri Stage A Revolution

Chapter Notes

> Disclaimer: I know nothing of coding or robots or viruses. I'm going to write what sounds right to me.
>
> And yes, that's going to be a bit different than canon. Sorry to any tech people, this is going to be completely wrong. Please suspend your disbelief.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I honestly can't believe Mom let us go on another mission," Glimmer gushed. "Especially with all the… explosions and whatnot."

"Probably because she wants us away from the Salinean siege," Catra said thoughtfully. "Because, let's be honest, we're going to do something dangerous and reckless sooner or later. May as well get us an ally while we're at it."

"Kyle's missing out," Bow said. "This is gonna be so cool!"

"Hey, he's learning to make fancy seafood," Catra argued. "I for one am not complaining at the fact he will be able to make *more* tasty food."

Glimmer wrinkled her nose. "Fish is not tasty. It's disgusting."

“Agree to disagree. Still, the rest of us get to do fun stuff!”

‘I’m excited to meet Entrapta,’ Rogelio signed, a grin stretching across his snout. ‘Her coding is awesome.’

“I know, right?!” Bow squealed. “And she’s a huge deal in the Etherian maker’s community. Wonder what she’d think of my sonic arrow?”

Glimmer snorted. “You made a sonic arrow? When will we ever need that?”

“If we get lost in a crowd?” Adora suggested.

“Maybe if we want to annoy our enemies to death,” Catra said flatly. “Do not shoot that accursed thing around me. I like my ears intact.”

Bow winced. “Yeah, I can see how that wouldn’t be great for you…”

Adora’s eyes widened. “Sweet coconuts, you’re right! Keep that evil Catra-hating arrow in your quiver, Bow!”

“Aw, you do care Adora,” Catra purred, looking genuinely touched.

“Of course your fiancée cares,” Glimmer cooed.

“spaRKLES-“

Rogelio looked confused for a minute, then he grinned. ‘I forgot about that. Are you planning the wedding?’

“Yes!” Bow squealed. “I’m making a firework arrow just for the occasion. It’ll be *epic* .”

‘I’m Catra’s best man, right?’ Rogelio asked. ‘I’m your favorite brother.’

“Sparkles already claimed-“ Catra stopped herself, going red. “All of you shut up!”

‘I guess I could officiate instead,’ Rogelio mused. ‘I assume Kyle is in charge of catering?’

“Duh,” Bow agreed. “And I got Perfuma to be in charge of the flowers.”

“I hate you all.”

“No you don’t.”

“No I don’t.”

“Hey,” Adora piped up. “Think there was a rock slide?” She pointed up ahead to where the trail was blocked by a cluster of boulders.

“Probably,” Bow agreed. “Any loud sound could cause another one. We need to be as quiet as-“

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!” Adora interrupted, transforming into She-Ra. She swiftly cleared the rocks from their path. “Ha! I think I’m getting the hang of this.”

“Well *that* was dumb,” Catra said flatly. “You could’ve killed us all.”

“But I didn’t,” She-Ra responded. “What’s the big deal?”

“The big deal is you’re an idiot,” Catra replied. “Be more careful.”

“Fine,” She-Ra sulked.

“Honestly, both you and Glimmer need to stop relying on magic so much,” Catra said. “She can run out of power and if you lose the sword you’re in serious trouble. You have actual training. Use it.”

“You’re just jealous,” Glimmer dismissed.

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Seriously. I’m jealous, and that’s why I can beat you when we spar eight times out of ten.”

Glimmer blushed. “I-uh… hey! Is that Dryl’s distress beacon?”

“Looks like it,” Bow agreed. “Weird. There haven’t been any reports of the Horde in this area.”

“Maybe they were surprised,” Catra suggested grimly.

‘If I can get close enough, I can hack into the security system,’ Rogelio signed. ‘We can survey the threat through the cameras and decide whether or not to engage.’

“Sounds like a plan,” Catra nodded. “Ro and I will get close. The rest of you are as subtle as a tank barreling down a hill on fire.”

" *Hey* !"

"Am I wrong?"

"…no."

Catra smirked. "C'mon, Ro."

"Wait!" Bow interjected. "Watch out for traps!"

"Got it!"

The pair walked over to the imposing castle walls, Catra carefully watching ahead to avoid falling victim to a trap. Rogelio signaled her as soon as he deemed them close enough, and withdrew a pad from his satchel. He typed on it, waited a few moments, then began typing again somewhat frantically. He sucked in a breath, frowning. Rogelio looked up, meeting Catra's mismatched eyes with his own worried black gaze.

'There's a virus in the system,' he signed. 'I can't get in.'

"You didn't find anything?"

‘The virus looks… old. Not the Horde.’

“So the system’s on the fritz?” Catra suggested. “Nothing is actually wrong?”

‘Maybe. Maybe not.’

They returned to the group. “So we have a problem,” Catra began. “The security system has a virus. We don’t know how far the damage goes, so we’re going to need to check it out physically.”

‘You guys go,’ Rogelio proposed. ‘I can code an antivirus, but it will take me some time.’

“Great,” Catra acknowledged. “Let’s do this.”

They approached the castle again, and She-Ra winced, rubbing her forehead.

Glimmer frowned, concerned. ”You okay?”

“This place feels wrong…” She-Ra said. “It's nothing.”

They entered the courtyard after dodging a few traps. It was eerily empty, the grey and purple color scheme accentuating the creepy feeling. Catra's ears pricked as a door screeched.

"Hey, who's there?" She-Ra called, receiving no answer.

Glimmer cupped her hands around her mouth. "Hello? Princess Entrapta. We're here to, uh, recruit you for the Rebellion."

A metal hand started crawling her. She shrieked, shaking it off and kicking it away.

"Well that's not promising," Catra muttered.

"Okay, we need to be careful." Bow warned. "Entrapta has traps set up all over her castle. They're supposed to be really cool. But with a virus…"

"I can see how that might be dangerous," Glimmer conceded.

There was a loud noise, and a manhole cover lifted to reveal an older lizard like lady. "They're coming!" she said. "Get out of the square!"

"Who's coming? Is it the Horde?" She-Ra asked.

“Hello? Come back,” Glimmer added.

Heavy clanking began to echo through the courtyard. Catra winced. “I don’t think we want to find out. We need to move.”

She-Ra pointed down a dark hallway. “This way.”

They started to head down it, only to stop short as a robot stumbled out of the shadows.

“What the-“

Catra leapt, kicking the robot firmly in the head. It went down hard, crumpling to the ground.

Bow knelt to study the fallen bot. “Looks like one of Entrapta's designs. Must have been affected by the virus.”

“That’s not good,” said Catra.

She-Ra drew her sword, preparing to beat down a door. “Alright, stand back. We should keep going.”

“Careful, it could be a-“ Bow cut off as Glimmer and She-Ra fell down into a pit.

“Glimmer! Adora!” Bow shouted.

“Idiots!” Catra growled, taking a wall with her claws in frustration. “They’re going to get themselves killed! Bow, let’s…” She trailed off, having turned back only to find Bow gone too. “Well crap.”

. . .

“Bow! Catra!” Glimmer shouted. “They’re all alone with those things! They need us!

“Um, Catra would literally kill you if she heard you say that,” She-Ra pointed out.

Glimmer paused. “True. They’re probably fine. But still… I'll teleport us out.”

They teleported into a small space. “Uh, is this out?” She-Ra asked.

Glimmer groaned and teleported again. They ended up teetering on a roof's edge. She quickly teleported a third time. The two then found themselves free falling towards a *very ominous* looking contraption. They quickly teleported a final time, landing in an empty hallway.

"Okay, no more teleporting from now on." She-Ra gasped out, looking decidedly uneasy.

"Sounds like a good idea." agreed Glimmer.

They spun as a clattering filled the hallway. A shape emerged from the vents, red eyes glowing menacingly.

"Not again," Glimmer groaned, hands lighting up with magic.

The shape emerged from the darkness, revealing itself to be none other than Entrapta. "Princesses! I'm saved!"

"Princess Entrapta?" Glimmer replied. "I mean, so good to see you. I hope you don't mind, but we sort of let ourselves in."

"And then we let ourselves out of your cage… trap thing." She-Ra added.

“Welcome to Dryl!” Entrapta greeted them. “Things are usually really fun around here, but right now it's all kind of teensy bit deadly.”

. . .

“Hey!” Catra barked. “Give me my friend back!”

“Please keep your voice down, ma’am,” one of the strangers holding Bow said. “The robots respond to sound.”

“We're just trying to help him,” a second, a plump woman, explained.

Catra relaxed her aggressive stance. “Thanks, I guess.”

“What's going on?” Bow asked. “Where did the virus come from?”

“We don't know.” The third person said sadly. “We're just the kitchen staff.”

“Miniature cupcake?” the second offered. “Princess Entrapta only eats tiny food.”

“And delicious fizzy beverages.” the first added.

“Uh, thank you?”

“You guys have names?” Catra said, glancing around the kitchen she’d followed the trio to.

“I’m Sodapop,” the first said. “That’s Buttercream-“ he pointed to the plump lady- “and Sprinkles.”

“Cool,” Catra replied. “I’m Princess Catra of Bright Moon. That’s Bow. He’s our arrow guy.”

“You'll be safe in here with us.” Buttercream assured them. “We've got enough food to last for months. It's tiny, but still.”

“The bots will run out of power eventually, right?” Sprinkles said hopefully.

“If Entrapta’s any good, not for a while,” Catra refuted.

Bow nodded. “Catra’s right. We need to do something. You can't just hide in here forever.”

“Oh yes we can. We don't have powers like the princesses. We can't - fight.” Sprinkles slumped.

“I’m a princess by adoption,” Catra replied. “I don’t have powers. Doesn’t mean I’m helpless.”

Bow’s pad beeped, causing a slight distraction.

Sodapop tensed. “Sir, kindly quiet your whatever that is.”

“It's a tracker pad,” Bow explained. “It tracks energy signatures from magic. It will help me find our friends.”

Buttercream frowned. “Are those little dot thingies your friends?”

As if in response, the door shook as robots roared outside.

Bow drew an arrow. “Gonna go with no.”

. . .

Rogelio frowned. The virus was like none he'd ever seen in his fourteen years of programming. It was constantly changing, updating, almost *alive* .

Worries persisted as he reread his draft of the antivirus. It was possible the virus could override the code, rendering it useless.

The best way to do this would be to hit the center of the virus, rewrite the strongest infection first. The whole rewrite would have to be fast, to be absolutely sure the virus had been completely scrubbed.

Which meant going *into* the infected castle.

Moons, he was beginning to act like his idiot siblings.

. . .

"Oh, the door won't hold much longer," Buttercream said worriedly.

"For crying out loud-" Catra yanked the door open, grabbed an empty bottle, and smashed the first bot's head in. She shoved the broken robot into a second, and dug her claws deep into the third. Growling, she roundhouse kicked the three robots out the door. "Sayonara, scrapheaps."

She slammed the door, then realized everyone was staring at her. "What?"

"That…" Sodapop stuttered. "How did you…"

"Those bots are pretty flimsy actually," Catra responded. "Not designed for combat. As long as you're fast, they're not all that threatening."

She shifted uncomfortably, stuffing a cupcake in her mouth. "Look," she mumbled around the cupcake. "You can hide in here, or you can be brave for a bit and get rid of the robots. Your choice."

The bakers shared a look, before grabbing makeshift weapons. "Lead the way," Sodapop declared.

. . .

A few minutes later, they ran into Adora, Glimmer, and Entrapta- almost literally. Glimmer looked a bit worse for wear, supporting a loopy Adora.

"What happened to Adora?" Catra demanded.

“Nice to see you too,” Glimmer muttered. “The sword got infected.”

“Heeeeeey, kitty,” Adora said, smiling stupidly. “You’re really pretty.”

“Are you blushing?” Glimmer said mischievously.

Catra smacked Glimmer. “Shut it, Sparkles. You okay, Adora?”

“Just peachy,” replied Adora. “Found my kitty, gonna marry her.”

“Where are these stupid bots?” Catra said, completely done. “I would like to kick some things. Violently.”

Rogelio ran up to them, tapping Catra’s shoulder urgently. Catra turned to him. “Whatchya got, Ro?”

‘I have an antivirus,’ Rogelio signed. ‘But we’ll need to reboot all the bots at once to make sure it’s effective.’

Bow grinned. “I have a great idea!”

. . .

"So we can all agree the trick arrow was a great idea?" Bow said smugly a few hours later.

"Fine, yes," Glimmer admitted. "And Rogelio is awesome, but we all knew that."

Rogelio smiled. 'I do my best.'

"So… where to now?" Adora asked.

"Mom wants us to take Willow to meet Lonnie," Catra replied. "Can't let her think just because she has a fancy school she's free of us."

"I haven't seen Lonnie in months!" Bow said nostalgically. "How's she doing at Mystacor?"

"Annoyingly she's amazing at everything," Catra grumbled, a slight smile betraying her fondness. "Real prodigy and whatnot."

“If she’s annoying, does that make me your favorite sister?” Glimmer asked hopefully.

“Not a chance, Sparkles.”

Chapter End Notes

I kinda skipped the fight scene in the end. Sorry. I hate writing those. If you’re unclear on how it went down, it basically went like this:
Bow shoots the sonic arrow
Catra rage smashes the bots
Rogelio breaks the disk and uploads his antivirus.

Now that that’s done, I can move on to the more fun chapters!

Glimmer and Lonnie Fight To The Death Of Everyone Else's Sanity

Chapter Notes

> So this is actually quite short, seeing as I kind of decided to forgo the episode's original plot. It's kind of a filler chapter but I think it's a fun chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So where are we going?" Willow asked, bouncing excitedly on Rogelio's shoulders.

"Mystacor," Glimmer answered cheerfully. "It's where our Aunt Casta and Lonnie live."

"Whoa," the little girl said. "What's that?"

"It's a secret, floating kingdom that's home to all of Etheria's sorcerers," Glimmer explained, eyes bright.

Kyle made a noise of disagreement. "I don't know, I've heard the Horde has a sorceress. Shady Lady or something."

"She sounds like a secretive manipulative egomaniac, she probably won't tell the Horde anyways," Catra snarked. "More info, more power. Bet she hordes it." A horrified expression crossed her face. "Oh Seraini, no, I didn't mean-"

“You PUNNED!” Bow exclaimed, grabbing the sputtering girl and shaking Catra hard enough to rattle her brain.

Catra locked eyes with Adora. “ *Kill me* .”

. . .

They walked up to the edge of pearly white cliffs, overlooking a vast sea of clouds. Willow seemed fascinated by the dazzling view.

“We’re here!” Glimmer announced.

“Um…” Willow said hesitantly. “Glimmer, this looks like… a long fall. With nothing there.”

Catra snorted. “Yeah, *Glimmer* , where’s the big impressive city we promised our favorite princess?”

Glimmer glared at Catra. “You’re the worst. Why am I related to you?”

“Technically, you’re not.”

“Technically, I’ve been stuck with you for like fifteen years.”

“What I’m *sure* Glimmer was eventually going to explain,” Kyle cut in, looking very much done with his sisters’ antics. “Is that Mystacor is hidden by a special spell. It makes it hard to find, so it’s safer.”

“That’s so cool!” Willow squealed. “How do we find it?”

In answer, Adora tackled Catra off the cliff.

Willow, understandably, screamed.

A few seconds later though, the two girls emerged on a platform that floated up so that it was level with the cliff.

“Anyone who isn’t named Willow or Glimmer can jump,” Catra called. “Sparkles, teleport Willie over.”

Glimmer readily agreed, presumably because it was Willow.

Catra, on the other hand, she still felt like throttling. As per usual.

The platform rose to meet a beautiful floating city, sparkling in morning light like an uncut gem. Willow's eyes were found as she tried to look at everything at once, eliciting fond smiles out of her older companions.

"It's so pretty," Willow whispered.

Rogelio smiled as he signed, 'it really is, little one.'

"Now that we're here, we get to deal with Aunt Overbearing," Catra grimaced. "She may be family, but… yikes."

"Don't be rude," Bow chastised.

"I mean, she can be a lot sometimes," Glimmer muttered.

'Just like Kyle handle her,' Rogelio suggested. 'He's her favorite.'

Kyle blushed. "Am not!"

"Are those my nieces and nephews?" an exuberant voice broke in, and they turned to see Castaspella hurrying up to them with a grinning Lonnie close behind. Lonnie looked different from the last

time they'd seen her. She wore a violet halter top and white palazzo pants. Gold beads sparkled in her hair. A staff was clutched tightly in her left hand, amethyst top gleaming in the morning light.

Collectively they shoved Kyle forward as their sacrificial lamb. He had just enough time to look betrayed before Castaspella practically suffocated him in a hug, Lonnie smirking behind her.

Kyle glared at Lonnie. Lonnie's grin widened. Kyle rolled his eyes, seeming to resign himself to being smothered. "Hey, Auntie Casta."

"You haven't visited in *so* long, I've missed you!" Castaspella dramatically declared. "And this must be Willow! I've heard so much about you!"

Willow scuffed her feet around shyly. "Hi."

Castaspella cooed. "You're adorable. Looking forward to getting to know my grandniece."

"Hey little one," Lonnie greeted her, crouching slightly. "I want you to know that I'm way cooler than my sisters."

Catra choked, outraged. "In your *dreams* , you second-rate magician."

Lonnie winked. “Fight me, pussy.”

“I notice you aren’t wearing your sweaters,” Castaspella interrupted, raising an eyebrow. “None of you. Don’t you like them?”

Catra tried very hard not to roll her eyes. “Aunt, it’s the middle of summer. I don’t have a death wish.”

“But you like them, right?”

“Of course!” Adora assured her, poorly.

“Really.”

“We’d tell you if we didn’t like them,” Kyle rushed in, glaring at his siblings in a way that screamed *whose idea was it to let* Adora *lie* .

“I’m wearing the socks you sent me,” Bow volunteered.

“We’ll wear the sweaters in wintertime,” Kyle finished.

"Well, anyways," Castaspella said, evidently deciding not to fight *that* battle, "how about we give my favorite grandniece a tour?"

"Sure!" Willow exclaimed happily.

Glimmer discreetly moaned.

"You're here at a great time, really, there's an eclipse coming up…"

Catra grabbed Adora quietly and dragged her away from the group. "We need to talk."

. . .

The two settled in a grassy clearing overlooking the clouds.

"So…" Adora said. "What did you want to tell me?"

Catra stared at the clouds, watching them shift and rise and fall. "Look. Ever since the whole incident with the demon bug, Sparkles and Rainbow have been… *very* intent on the idea that we, apparently, should get married."

Adora flushed. “Yeah,” she agreed quietly. “Look, if this is about me not really saying anything, it’s just… weird. Because…” Here she looked down, ears burning, “I do like you, Catra. Like that, I mean.”

“I know,” Catra said, surprising her. “You’re many things, Adora. Subtle is not and will never be one of them.”

Adora nodded. “So you don’t like me too.” Her heart dropped, and she curled up a little on the grass. “That’s-that’s okay. I’ll give you some space-“

“One thing you *are* ,” Catra broke in, pushing Adora’s chin up with a finger so they locked eyes, “is an idiot.”

“Huh?”

“I *do* like you, dummy,” she replied fondly, mismatched eyes twinkling. “Have for years. Honestly, you’re the last to know.”

“I- *what* ?”

Catra laughed. “You’re so stupid.”

The two girls locked eyes, both smiling brightly. “So…” Adora said. “Will you be my girlfriend?”

“No,” Catra said sarcastically. “That’s why I just confessed, idiot. Of course I’ll be your girlfriend.”

Adora’s smile widened. “Wow,” she whispered.

Catra stopped smiling and looked at her sternly. “We are not engaged though.”

Adora wilted slightly.

“You don’t get to ask the question till we’re *both* eighteen,” Catra finished.

Adora’s mouth flapped for a minute before she regained control of her brain. “Uh-huh. Few months then. I can do that.”

“Dummy.”

“ *Your* dummy.”

“My dummy.”

. . .

“Hey, where did Adora and Catra go?” Bow asked as they entered the Lunarium.

“Probably making out somewhere,” Glimmer snorted.

Rogelio clapped his hands around Willow’s ears, glaring at his sister.

“Are they finally together?” Lonnie wondered. “Officially?”

“Better,” Kyle grinned wickedly. “Remember the whole we’ll-get-married-when-you’re-eight-feet-tall-thing? Well now Adora can turn into She-Ra, so…”

Lonnie cackled. “That’s the best thing I’ve heard in years. When’s the wedding?”

“I’m thinking a spring wedding would be nice,” Bow replied. “Kyle’s in charge of the catering, Princess Perfuma offered to do some floral arrangements, and Glimmer’s the best man.”

Lonnie’s eyes narrowed. “What.”

“Uh-oh…” Kyle whispered.

“Glimmer,” Lonnie said dangerously. “ *Why* are you the best man?”

Glimmer, because she had no sense of self-preservation, answered, “Because I’m the best sister. Obviously.”

“Oh you did *not* -“ Lonnie sputtered, looking murderous. “You. Me. Duel. Now. Winner is the best man.”

“No fair!” Glimmer complained. “You’ve been basically training for this for *years* .”

“And what have you been doing?” Lonnie sassed. “Never knew you to back down from a fight.”

Glimmer’s eyes hardened, and she stomped outside. Rogelio sighed wearily. ‘Come little one,’ he signed, beckoning to Willow. ‘This will be fun to watch.’

“Why are my sisters idiots?” Kyle moaned, but followed the rest of the group outside. The boys and Willow settled on the grass, Rogelio and Kyle directing Willow’s attention to the sky.

Glimmer and Lonnie took up stances about fifteen feet away from each other, and swiftly drew runes. In a burst of light, two illusions appeared, soaring upwards. Glimmer had crafted a large pink bear, while Lonnie had chosen to shape her violet champion as a jaguar.

The bear roared, swiping at the jaguar. Willow shrieked in delight as the jaguar danced away before leaping at the bear, which shook it off, spraying sparks that were reminiscent of fireflies.

“That all you got?” Glimmer taunted, hands moving rapidly as she puppeteer her illusion into a counter strike.

“I’m just getting started!” Lonnie yelled back. The jaguar crouched beneath the bear’s swipe and rammed its head into the bear’s stomach. The bear staggered, jaw snapping wildly. Smirking, Lonnie went for the kill. The jaguar raked its claws across the bear’s chest, causing the larger creature to burst into fragments of light.

“Oh *come on* !” Glimmer complained. “Why are you *so good* at this?!”

“Probably because she practices more, Sparkles,” came Catra’s dry response. She and Adora sat down beside the rest of the spectators.“What made you two duel this early?”

“I just won the right to be your best man,” Lonnie said smugly.

“Best out of three!” Glimmer angrily demanded.

Catra just groaned. “Willie, have you seen the beach yet?”

“No!” Willow chirped.

“Well, in that case I will leave you idiots,” Catra rolled her eyes, grabbing Willow’s hand. “Anyone *not* bent on fighting is welcome to come.”

“I’ll come!” Adora volunteered. “Be a good girlfriend and whatnot.”

“Before any of you ask, yeah, we’re dating,” Catra said. “Make a big deal out of it and I will remove your kneecaps.”

“Always a joy, Catra,” Lonnie smirked. “Nice to see you too.”

“How’s fancy wizard school?”

“Eh,” Lonnie replied. “It’s been great, but I think I’m ready to go home.”

Catra blinked. “Really?”

“It’s getting boring. You should know by now that our family is allergic to boredom.”

Chapter End Notes

In the tags I said minor Catradora.

I may have accidentally lied. Sorry.

On to Princess Prom!

The Best Friend Squad Try (And Fail) To Avoid A Diplomatic Catastrophe

Chapter Notes

Honesty, this might be my favorite chapter so far.

I changed some of the outfits BECAUSE I FELT LIKE IT. dEaL wItH iT.

Half of this is mother-daughter bonding and the other half is basically just Catradora. Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Guys!” Adora burst into Glimmer's room, where the royal siblings were gathered. “Guess who got an invitation to Princess Prom?!”

“All of us!” Glimmer sang, dancing around the room. “Well, except Bow.”

“Still going!” Bow cheered.

“I don’t see the big deal,” Catra complained halfheartedly. “It’s a big party, so what?”

“Big party?” Bow sputtered. “It’s a huge rite of passage!”

“And it could be our first date?” Adora offered hopefully.

Catra blinked. “Yeah, okay then.”

Glimmer fake-coughed. “ *Whipped* .”

Catra growled, grabbed Glimmer, and chucked her off the balcony. Glimmer reappeared a second later, none too happy.

“Anyways, it’s a great diplomatic opportunity!” Kyle hurried to say, presumably to stop Glimmer from murdering Catra. “What with the Kingdom of Snows hosting.”

“That’s true!” Glimmer agreed, mercifully distracted. “Bow, Kyle, and I should head up that front.”

“Hey, why not Rogelio or Catra or me?” Adora protested.

“Because most people don’t speak sign language and you’re terrible at diplomacy. Also, Catra is perhaps the most aggravating person I’ve ever met.”

“It’s a gift,” Catra drawled. “Any of us taking plus ones? I was gonna take Adora before the whole She-Ra thing.”

“Aww!” Adora cooed, starry eyed.

“Get a room,” Kyle teased. “But actually, yeah. I asked Sprinkles.”

“The busser lady from Dryl?” Bow said.

“Yep,” confirmed Kyle. “She’s cool. Aspiring food critic.”

“Ooh, Kyle’s got a *girlfriend* ,” Glimmer said, delighted.

Kyle snorted. “Not Sprinkles.”

He walked out the door.

“…does that mean he *does* have a girlfriend?”

“Who knows?” Adora said. “Are you taking anyone, Ro?”

‘Yes,’ Rogelio signed. ‘Seneschal.’

They all nodded. It came as no surprise: Seneschal and Rogelio had been dating for several months now.

“Lonnie?”

“Naw,” Lonnie grinned. “Can’t really flirt if you bring a date.”

“And I’m bringing Bow, of course,” Glimmer concluded.

“Um… actually…” Bow said sheepishly. “I’m going with Perfuma.”

“whAT?!”

“O- *kay* , let’s go talk… dresses or… something,” Adora hurried. She grabbed Glimmer and Lonnie and headed out the door, Catra hot on her heels.

Bow blinked. “What just happened?”

. . .

“He can go with who he wants!” Glimmer insisted, flopping on Karma’s bed. “I just- it’s fine!”

“Face it, Sparkles, you’re jealous,” Catra said, trying on a jacket. “If it makes you feel better, I don’t think Flowers is Bow’s type.”

“I- I’m not-“

Glimmer’s red-faced sputtering was mercifully interrupted by Karma and Willow entering the bedroom and finding the girls there.

“So, Princess Prom?” Karma said warmly. “That’s exciting.”

“Mm-hm,” Lonnie hummed her agreement. “Weren’t you supposed to be in Salineas?”

“And miss my girls’ first ball?” Karma smiled, grabbing a brush and beginning to work on Adora’s hair. “Absolutely not. Juliet is in charge.”

“You had better not come near me with that thing,” Catra threatened, eyeing the brush.

“First ball, Catra,” Karma reminded her daughter. “I’ll only insist twice. Now, and when you get married.”

“Fiiiiiiiine.”

“Firecracker, Little Moon, do you know what you’re wearing?”

“Yep!” Glimmer perked up. “I’ve had it picked out for ages!” She picked up a violet spaghetti strap dress. “What do you think?”

“It’s lovely. I think it would go well with you diamond choker.”

“Ooh, good idea!”

“I’m wearing this,” Lonnie said. She displayed a sleeveless V-neck dress that faded from purple to red. “And my crescent moon necklace.”

“Very nice,” Karma approved. “Break some hearts, kitten.”

“Always.”

“I don’t know what to wear,” Adora admitted. “Clothes aren’t really my thing.”

“Be right back!” Glimmer shouted, running off.

“I wish I were going to Princess Prom,” Willow said sadly.

“Sorry, kitten,” Karma sighed. “You aren’t quite old enough.”

Willow pouted.

“You can still dress up, though.”

“Yay!” Willow cheered. “Lonnie, could you do my hair?”

“‘Course,” Lonnie replied, picking up a brush.

Glimmer came back in, clutching a pile of dresses. “Okay Adora! How about this one?” She held up a frilly maroon dress.

Catra snorted. “Glimmer, *none* of us would wear that.”

“…point taken. This one?” The second was an aqua mermaid dress with gold embellishments.

“Ooh, that’s nice,” Lonnie replied.

“Why can’t I just go as She-Ra?” Adora complained. “My hair looks way cooler when I’m her.”

“No weapons rule.”

“Yeah, I *know* that, but- hey, could I wear this?” She picked up a gold collared white dress. “It kinda reminds me of my She-Ra outfit.”

“That *would* look pretty sweet,” Glimmer agreed. “You can borrow my gold high heels.”

“Uh-uh,” Lonnie said immediately. “Remember the Plumeria Incident?”

“Oh. Right. Well, maybe wear some nice flats instead.”

“That was *three years ago* , let it go,” Adora grumbled. “And it was not that bad.”

“Oh really?” Catra deadpanned. “I seem to recall several dignitaries on fire and-“

“Girls,” Karma chided playfully. “I’m done with Adora’s hair. Who’s next?”

“Me!” Glimmer volunteered. She took Adora’s spot as the other girl went into the bathroom to change into her dress.

“Done!” Lonnie sang, giving Willow a mirror. She’d braided the younger girl’s hair into braids much like her own.

Willow beamed. “Thanks!”

“If you bring me the stuff I’ll do your makeup,” Glimmer offered. Willow picked up the makeup bag and trotted over to sit in front of Glimmer.

“Do I look okay?” Adora asked nervously, stepping out of the bathroom. Her elegant french braid was accented by a gold hairpin, matching her pair of cuffs.

Catra stared for a second too long, before hurrying to say, “Yeah, you look… okay.”

“You look lovely, kitten,” Karma said, nodding approvingly. “Catra, it’s your turn.”

Catra blanched. “Wait, what? You barely *just* got started on Glimmer’s hair.”

“Glimmer’s hair is rather short,” Karma replied dryly.

Catra reluctantly took Glimmer’s place, who shifted so as to keep doing Willow’s makeup.

“What are you gonna wear, Catra?” Glimmer asked. “You haven’t picked yet.”

“That blue dress is fine,” Catra said neutrally, picking at the discarded dress Glimmer had offered Adora.

“Yeah, that’ll work,” decided Glimmer. “ *You* could actually pull off my gold high heels.”

. . .

The Kingdom of Snows glittered with light and rang with laughter, the very picture of a sophisticated and exclusive party.

“I hate it here,” Catra said immediately.

“You hate everywhere,” Glimmer pointed out. “Salineas, Dryl, Plumeria…”

“Bright Moon is acceptable,” Catra refuted. “As well as Mystacor. Sometimes.”

“Dryl’s not so bad…” Sprinkles mumbled, “You know, without the killer robots.”

“Salineas has a rich culinary history,” Kyle said. “Plumeria has some decent cuisine, too. Don’t be so quick to judge.”

Catra stuck her tongue out at Kyle. “I’ll judge what I *like* , thank you very much.”

“Wow, mature,” Lonnie snarked.

“OKAY!” Adora practically shouted. “Time to go meet the hostess.”

They managed to make it through the obligatory pleasantries without issue by some miracle. Sprinkles and Kyle immediately gravitated towards the refreshments, while Rogelio went to go talk to Entrapta. Lonnie grabbed Glimmer’s hand. “C’mon, let’s go flirt with the Star Sisters.”

“But-I-what?!” Glimmer sputtered.

“No time to be mopey cause your crush isn’t going with you,” Lonnie replied. “Be petty.”

“But the mission!”

“Can wait! Let’s have some fun!”

“…fine.”

Adora and Catra went up to the balcony, watching the party from their place of relative tranquility.

“So…” Adora said. “What do people do on a date?”

“Lonnie says people usually get to know each other on the first date,” Catra replied. “Obviously, that’s not very helpful for us.”

“Want to play Truth or Dare?” Adora offered, eyes sparkling.

“What is this, a sleepover?” Catra said, but her mouth twitched upwards treacherously. “Fine. Let’s just agree no causing diplomatic catastrophes.”

“Fair enough. If either of us chicken out, we have to go get the other person something from the refreshments table.”

“No alcohol?” Catra complained. “You’re no fun.”

“We’re seventeen, Catra. Princesses breaking the law could cause a diplomatic incident.”

“Good point. You want to go first?”

“Truth or dare, Catra?”

“Dare, duh.”

“Hm…” Adora mused, tapping her chin theatrically. “I dare you to throw this at Glimmer.” She held out a cloth ball she had been fidgeting with.

“Didn’t even need to ask,” Catra smirked, grabbing the ball and lobbing it at her sister. The pink haired princess jolted in surprise, looking up from her conversation with the Star Sisters at the balcony accusingly. Catra gave her a cheeky wave.

“She looks like she’s about to actually murder you.”

“That’s just her resting face.”

Both girls were choking on laughter. “Hey, Adora,” Catra said. “Truth or dare?”

“Truth.”

“Boring,” Catra booed.

“Well, think of a good question, then.”

“If you had to eat one of us, who would you eat?”

“ *What* ?! Why would I ever need to eat someone?!”

Catra shrugged. “Deserted island, prisoner, take your pick.”

“This is an evil question!”

“Then go get me a cupcake.”

"…Glimmer," Adora relented.

Catra snorted. "Why?"

"She looks like she's made out of cake. Eat the rich."

" *We're* rich, idiot."

"I'm a class traitor."

"Stop lying and ask me the question."

"Will you marry me?"

"Not *that* question!"

Their argument was interrupted as they caught sight of two guests arriving. "Is that…" Adora trailed off.

"The Horde scum girl? Yeah."

"What's *she* doing here?"

“I don’t know, but we shouldn’t make a scene. We need to handle this calmly and-“

“HORDE SCUM!” Glimmer screeched, pointing at Rosa and Scorpia.

“…aaaaaaand Glimmer’s already thrown that out the window.”

“Revered hostess, you can’t let them in!” Glimmer insisted, pushing her way to the front of the room. “They’re from the Horde!”

“Revered hostess,” Rosa purred, eyes gleaming. “We have broken no rules. Princess Scorpia was invited. There is no reason to refuse us, as this is, after all, neutral ground.”

“They may stay, as per the rules, Princess Glimmer.”

“But-“

“Enjoy the ball.”

Adora grabbed Catra’s hand. “They’re up to something, right?”

“I… don’t know,” Catra admitted. “It’s possible they just want to foster sympathy for the Horde.”

“We should keep an eye on them!”

“Yeah, we *could* do that,” Catra said. “Or we can get *our* mission done.”

“But-“

Glimmer joined them on the balcony, visibly fuming. A much more calm Lonnie followed. “We need to stop them!”

“We don’t even know what they’re doing,” Catra pointed out. “How about Lonnie follows Rosa and Glimmer shadows Scorpia. Meanwhile, Adora and I will chat with Frosta.”

“…alright,” Glimmer relented.

“Do I get to flirt with Rosa?” Lonnie asked. “She’s kinda cute, if a bit conniving.”

“You need help,” Catra deadpanned. “But sure, whatever.”

They split up. Catra and Adora approached their diminutive hostess, both bowing respectfully.

"Are you here to tell me how to make decisions like your sister?" Frosta said suspiciously.

"Nope," Catra popped the last syllable. "Quite honestly I'd be somewhat concerned if you listened to Glimmer. Actually, we were hoping to meet you. Officially."

"It's Catra, right?" Frosta said. "The blood daughter of Karma. Your mom tried to adopt me."

Catra nodded, exasperated. "Yeah, that's her. I swear I have like fifteen siblings by now."

"The only reason I'm not legally adopted is because Mama decided I'm marrying in."

"I think she's trying to adopt Entrapta, despite her being a fully grown adult."

Frosta smiled hesitantly. "So that's… normal for her?"

“Oh absolutely,” Catra agreed. “You can probably expect a nickname and presents for every birthday.”

“…noted.”

“The Kingdom of Snows is so pretty,” Adora said. “It’s really cool.”

Catra glared at her. “If that pun was intended I will dump you.”

“Pun?”

“That’s what I thought.”

Frosta barked a laugh. “You two seem like you’d make great sisters.”

“You too,” Catra grinned.

“You two get ready,” Frosta said. “I’m about to start the dancing.” She raised her voice. “It is my solemn duty as hostess to now announce this: it is time for the first dance of the Ball!”

Catra and Adora pressed their hands together and began the dance. “This is fun,” Adora said.

“Surprisingly,” Catra agreed. “Sending you to Glimmer now. I do *not* want to deal with… whatever that is.”

Adora twirled over to Glimmer, who was sobbing. “I got into a fight with Bow and he won't wanna be friends with me anymore and I don't know where Scorpia is!”

“Um…” Adora said intelligently, before Perfuma cut in.

“Where is Bow? He left a while ago to get his cummerbund, but that was a while ago, right about the same time Scorpia left.”

“You’re on first name terms with Scorpia?” Adora responded. “Wait, never mind… Glimmer! Where did you last see Bow?”

“A while ago…” Glimmer bit her lip. “Near the bathrooms, I think.” She grabbed Catra. “Come on. We need to find Bow.”

“What about the rest of the boys?” Adora asked urgently. “Or Lonnie, for that matter? I can’t remember seeing them in a while.”

“We better check it out.” With a look of steely determination, Glimmer teleported the three of them near the bathrooms.

Glimmer glanced down a hallway, bending down. “Is that…” She touched the dark spot on the floor, fingers coming away wet. “Guys?”

She turned to find Adora and Catra unconscious, held by two of Frosta’s guards. Rosa smirked, flanked on either side by the disguised Horde soldiers. “Check.”

The world went dark.

Chapter End Notes

Well that went well.

Adora too has been kidnapped? Who will save them now?!

Rosa may be smart but she forgot one very important detail. I’ll let you guys guess what that is.

Karma Raids Area 51

Chapter Notes

> Wow, this chapter has an unholy amount of dialogue.
>
> Okay, disclaimer: I have no expertise in like, anything. Things probably do not work the way I say they do.
>
> Suspend your disbelief. It's way better when you pretend it makes sense.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"They did WHAT?!" Karma roared.

"The Horde *took* them!" Perfuma cried, tearing up.

"We can't find them anywhere!" Seneschal added. The Plumerian looked extremely depressed at the disappearance of his boyfriend.

"And they didn't take *me* !"

They all looked at Sea Hawk strangely. "What?" he said. "I'm a full member of this Alliance. Am I not good enough to be kidnapped?"

"I'm going to eviscerate whoever's in charge and feed them their organs," Karma growled. "Who the shining stars do they think they are?!"

“Ooh!” Frosta said. “Are we gonna punch the Horde?”

Karma’s grin was downright feral. “Oh, I intend to do far more than just that.”

. . .

Catra was not a happy camper.

Seriously, she finally got to go on a date with her childhood crush and the Horde decides to waltz in and kidnap them?

The *audacity* .

“Okay, punks, what gives?” she snarled. “What do you want?”

Rosa regarded her flatly. “I think you can guess. You’re the daughter of General Karma.”

Pugna nodded enthusiastically. “And as your mother’s only child-“

“What are you talking about?” Catra interrupted. “My mama has like a dozen kids. It’s actually getting to be kind of ridiculous.”

“Wait, what?” Pugna said. “I thought you were her only kid?”

“Only biological,” corrected Catra.

Pugna frowned. “So even if they aren’t related to you, people can have parents?”

Rosa sighed. “Stop trying to think, Pugna. It hurts to watch.”

“But I want parents…”

“Good glory, keep her away from my mama,” grumbled Catra.

“Enough,” Rosa commanded. “We’re arriving at the Fright Zone. Tina, Will, take those three” she pointed to the boys. “Without weapons, they aren’t terribly dangerous. Lock them up in the normal cells and keep an eye on them.”

Will saluted. “Yes, Force Captain.”

“The rest of you, take Princesses Glimmer, Lonnie, and Catra to the Black Garnet Chamber.”

“Wait, what about Adora?” Catra demanded.

Rosa smirked. “Let‘a just say she’s going to help me out with a pet project.”

. . .

“So these are your cells,” Tina said, gesturing at the inhospitable rooms. “Have a nice stay?”

Will rubbed his forehead. “Tina… you know what? I don’t care. Just watch the prisoners and don’t screw up.”

“Oh. Okay,” Tina replied. “I can do that.”

Tina settled in front of Kyle’s cell, watching Will leave. She turned to the blond boy as soon as Will was gone, curiosity shining in her big brown eyes.

“So… you’re in the Rebellion?”

"Uh, yeah," Kyle said, startled. "Kind of, anyways. I'm more of a chef."

"You make rations?"

Kyle made a horrified face. "No way. I remember that crap they tried to tell us was food when I was here. My creations are actually edible."

"You've been here before?" Tina started.

"Oh yeah," Kyle responded. "Mama rescued us. Best thing that ever happened to us. I mean, do you really like it here?"

"Of course!" Tina said immediately, then paused. "Well… I mean… it's home. I don't have anywhere else to go."

Kyle nodded. "If you could live anywhere, where would you live?"

Tina stilled, considering the question. It was a bad, bad, *bad* idea to even be thinking of this. Treason. The Horde was her home, her *only* home…

And yet…

She allowed herself a tiny, wistful smile. “Salineas was nice. I liked the sea.”

“Me too!” Kyle said. “Especially with the seafood. I could eat fish all day.”

Tina decided not to tell him she had no idea what a ‘fish’ was.

. . .

“The Horde is demanding our surrender in exchange for our children,” Angella said shakily. “I think we should-“

“The Horde can shove their demands up their overinflated ego. Stars knows it’s big enough,” Karma snapped. “Entrapta, do you have the bombs?”

“Yep!”

Angella rubbed her forehead. “I forgot why I was worried.”

. . .

“I’m gonna freaking *murder* all of you,” Catra threatened. “Where is my girlfriend?”

Shadow Weaver stared flatly at Catra. “I remember you. You were the worst.”

“Gee, thanks,” Catra replied sarcastically. “Who are you anyways?”

“I am Shad-“

“THAT’S THE SHADY LADY!” Glimmer burst in.

Even with the mask on, Shadow Weaver managed to look affronted. “Excuse me, my name is not-“

“Oh yeah!” interrupted Catra. “The Sorcerer School dropout?”

“I was not a *dropout* -“

“I mean, kind of a lame sorceress,” Lonnie said, ignoring Shadow Weaver. “Like, the Horde doesn’t even use magic. What does she even do?”

Shadow Weaver was about to burst a blood vessel. "Listen *here* , you insolent brats-"

"Jump scares people?" Catra suggested. "I mean, what's with the getup? Are you going for scary depressed angsty goth lady? Because you're failing at one and succeeding at another, Shady Lady."

"Stop calling me that!"

"If I promise to call you something else, will you tell me where Adora is?"

Shadow Weaver actually looked tempted, but she just shook her head. "We dodged a bullet. I hate all of you."

. . .

"So you've grown up with your squad?" Kyle asked. "What's that like? Are they nice to you?"

From her spot curled up a few feet away, Tina shrugged. "Pugna is, in her own way. She really cares about all of us, even if she's not very bright. Will is sometimes nice. Victor is a jerk. Always has been. And Rosa…" She trailed off. "Rosa's… not like the rest of us."

“How so?”

“Well, for one, she’s *smart* . I mean, Will’s pretty smart, but Rosa’s on another level. She doesn’t quite think the same way, either. Plans within plans within plans. Always another route, another road to the same goal.”

“What is her goal?”

Tina hesitated. “You mean, besides helping the Horde? I don’t know. I don’t know that she cares all that much about the cause. She pretends, but… I’m good at reading people. Rosa has her own plans.”

Kyle nodded. He cocked his head at the girl. “Why are you telling me this?”

Tina smiled, slightly. “I don’t know. Maybe because you *listen* . Everyone else is too busy for me.”

“I know the feeling,” agreed Kyle. “All my siblings are amazing. They have so much talent, and that takes time. Sometimes I feel a bit left behind.”

“That doesn’t make sense.”

"Why not?"

"Because I haven't known you for long, but I know that you're pretty amazing in your own right."

Kyle smiled. "Thanks."

Tina smiled back, before the grin slowly faded. "We're not the good guys, are we."

It was not a question.

"The Horde?" Kyle clarified. "No. The Horde took my sibling and I away from our families when we were kids. They've destroyed countless villages, and honestly, can you say you *like* living here?"

Tina bit her lip. "I didn't realize till I saw how others lived. But this… this isn't right."

"It isn't," Kyle said calmly. "So what are you going to do?"

Tina clenched her fists. "Could the Rebellion use a spy?"

. . .

"I must admit," Rosa said, "You're not what I was expecting."

Adora frowned. "Oh really, Horde girl?"

"Your girlfriend would make a far better She-Ra," the albino continued, unfazed. "She's smart and talented. You… you're just a dumb jock."

"Is that supposed to hurt?"

"No." Rosa replied simply. "It's an observation, not an insult."

"You need to work on your people skills, psycho lady."

"And you need to let go of your weakness," returned Rosa.

"Why do you care?"

Rosa snorted. "Are you familiar with the concept of antibodies?"

“Um… no,” Adora admitted.

“Exposure to illnesses builds strength in the body,” Rosa said. “Nothing ever gets stronger by indulging in weakness. There’s always another threat, and you could be a powerful weapon in someone’s hands, provided you don’t get yourself killed first.”

“You’re paranoid.”

“Am I?” Rosa asked mildly. “Here’s the truth, Adora. The world is not a kind place. If it was, when we faced hardships we would perish. You don’t forge a sword with kind words and smiles. It takes heat and hammer, constant blows and immense pressure.”

Adora flinched. “Seriously, what is your issue? What are you trying to do?”

Rosa laughed mirthlessly. “I’m not going to tell you everything. You have your place in the game. Important as you may be, you are not the one pulling the strings.”

Rosa leaned forward, hands beginning to glow. “I am.”

. . .

Glimmer’s restraints suddenly began sparking, cutting off the argument that had been raging for about two hours now.

“Is that normal?!” Catra shouted.

“No, it isn’t,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Sparkles! You okay?!”

Glimmer’s only reply was a pain filled scream.

“Hey!” Lonnie barked from within her containment circle. “Get those off her!”

“That might make it worse!” Shadow Weaver snapped. “I don’t even know what it’s *doing* !”

“Teleport out!”

“She literally can’t!”

"…do it anyways!"

. . .

"This is so fun!" Entrapta shrieked over the comms. "I should pilot drones more often!"

"Glad to hear it, Gears," Karma replied. "How close are you to the drop site?"

"Close!"

"Great. Arsonist, Flower Boy, Flower Girl, Winter's Bane, you ready?"

Sea Hawk, Seneschal, Perfuma, and Frosta all answered the affirmative.

"All right then. Get ready to move."

"Dropping the payload now!"

A loud *crack!* rang out, and the team's stolen helmets buzzed and heated up, almost uncomfortably.

"That might be painful to some Horde soldiers," Karma said, utterly unrepentant.

"What was that?" Frosta demanded.

"EMP," Karma replied. "Electromagnetic pulse. Basically we just destroyed all their tech. And our comms, but… sunk cost."

Frosta blinked. "Why didn't you do that before?"

"It's kind of experimental," Karma admitted. "And it'll probably only work once. We *were* going to try a full scale invasion once we could recruit enough troops, but… I'm being selfish."

"How long till it wears off?" Perfuma asked.

"It won't." Karma grinned. "The circuits overheat and damage themselves. They'll need to replace almost everything. And if we're lucky, it could cause some electrical fires."

"Excellent," Sea Hawk laughed.

“This doesn’t seem right, morally?” Perfuma tentatively ventured.

“Neither is kidnapping children. The Horde are committing war crimes. It’s necessary to take some extreme measures to stop them.”

Perfuma reluctantly nodded.

The group fell silent, pulling on their helmets. They ran forward, mixing into the crowd of frantic soldiers trying to figure out *what the actual heck* was going on.

“Meet up here,” Karma said in a low tone.

They split up.

. . .

Tina jumped when the lights went out. “Think that’s your friends?”

“Probably,” responded Kyle. “This seems like something Mama would do.”

Tina nodded, fully aware he couldn't see her. "All right. You've knocked me out, and since the power is down, there's no one to stop you if you, say, took a few lucky turns. Like left where the hallway branches, right, right, and then up the stairs."

"Thanks," Kyle said. "Hopefully I'll see you soon."

"As a diligent and loyal Horde soldier, I can't return the sentiment. Go get your siblings."

. . .

Karma and Frosta burst into the Black Garnet chamber. Shadow Weaver quit arguing and trying to figure out Glimmer's situation and turned to the intruders.

"Surprise!" Karma said, grabbing Shadow Weaver by the legs and hurling her into the wall. Frosta broke Lonnie and Catra out, then stopped at Glimmer's side, stumped.

Glimmer finally managed to teleport, appearing with a flash of sparkles next to Karma. "Hey Mama, I did it!" She then promptly passed out.

"Glimmer!"

The two recently freed prisoners and their rescuers crowded around the fallen girl.

"This isn't good," Lonnie said nervously. "She needs medical attention. Now."

Karma nodded. "Let's hope the other group is having more luck."

. . .

Perfuma almost slammed into Rogelio while trying to navigate the dark halls. "There you are! Hey guys!"

"Rogelio!" Seneschal cried happily, hugging the lizard man. "I missed you!"

"We should leave while we have the chance!" Kyle urged.

"What about the others?"

"General Karma will find them," Sea Hawk said. "Away, friends! Adventure!"

. . .

“Headcount!” Karma barked as they all boarded a skiff. “Lonnie!”

“Here!”

“Catra!”

“Here!”

“Glimmer!”

“Mrrrrrggh…”

“That’s… not a good sign… Kyle!”

“Here!”

“Rogelio?”

“Here!”

“Adora!”

Silence. Karma took a deep breath. “Okay, I’ll go back and get Adora. Are we missing anyone else?”

“No,” Kyle replied.

“We might not have time,” Lonnie said reluctantly. “I don’t know what’s happening with Glimmer, but she needs help.”

“So we split up,” Karma proposed.

An explosion rocked the skiff.

“I don’t think we can make it separated,” Catra admitted reluctantly. “Not with this level of chaos.”

Karma squeezed her eyes shut, then roared, tossing a Horde helmet practically into orbit. “I hate it. But… we’ll be back.”

It was impossible not to feel like her heart was tearing in two as she left a kitten behind.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, so… canon’s kind of gone off the rails.

Welcome to the chaos!

You know, in this episode I really wanted Kyle to defect and join the Squad. That’s probably at least partially responsible for this AU.

Catra Pulls A Benjamin Franklin

Chapter Notes

I LIVE!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

No one spoke on their way back to Bright Moon. Karma gripped the skiff's railing so hard her claws left indents, her eyes never leaving her kids.

Finally, Perfuma spoke up.

"I'm so sorry Karma-"

"Don't," Karma snapped. "We're getting her back. Don't talk like she's dead."

Perfuma bowed her head in response. "This only happened because we were together. Nothing good comes from an alliance."

Catra hissed at her. "That's just stupid. If we don't work together we're easier to fight and we'll just die separately. Chopped up in tiny pieces."

Perfuma blinked. "That's… actually a good point."

“It’s not like the old methods were working,” Catra snarled, clutching the railing. “So we are going to work *smarter* and save my girlfriend. Understood?”

“Absolutely,” Kyle said.

“Never leave a sister-in-law behind!” Lonnie said, smiling half heartedly at her joke.

“So here’s the plan,” Karma began. “We need to go back to Bright Moon and get all of the former prisoners checked on. Meanwhile, I will meet with a few of our contacts, and Perfuma, Frosta, Entrapta and Sea Hawk will collaborate to correct my rough map of the Fright Zone. We may need that.”

“I am not sitting around while Adora is with that lunatic Rose!” Catra screeched.

“Thought her name was Rosa?” Bow said.

“Who cares?! Point still stands.”

“Not sitting around,” Karma corrected. “Making sure you’re okay. Then you’re welcome to help me find my daughter-in-law.”

. . .

After arriving in Bright Moon (and nearly being strangled in a hug from Angella *and* Willow), Karma forced her remaining kids to be checked over. For the most part, they were fine, if a bit weary. Glimmer, on the other hand, was not all right. Something strange seemed to be affecting her powers.

This condition did not lower Angella nor Karma's blood pressure *at all* .

"All right!" Karma announced. "New plan. Catra, you and I will go meet with the contacts. Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle and Seneschal, I need you to research magical ailments. Bow, Willow, keep Glimmer from doing anything stupid."

"I resent that," Glimmer said wearily.

"Angella, can you hold down the fort?" Karma asked, ignoring Glimmer.

"Yes," Angella agreed. "I can also coordinate our doctors."

"Guys, it's fiiiiiine," Glimmer whined. "I probably just need to recharge."

“We’ll definitely try that,” Angella assured her. “But I doubt that it will fix the problem.”

. . .

“That *plan* of yours was foolish!” Shadow Weaver bellowed. “You let our hostages escape!”

“ *I’m* foolish?!” Rosa repeated incredulously, temper burning up white hot in an instant.The words came pouring out of her mouth, sharp and ugly, full of fire. “You’re one to talk, you decrepit, decaying old *hag* ! You try to manipulate your way through life, but anyone with *eyes* can see you for the creepy pedophile you are!”

As soon as the words were out of her mouth, she regretted them. Not because they weren’t true- every one was an accurate reflection of her view on Shadow Weaver. But because she knew she poked the sleeping bear.

Before, she’d been in Shadow Weaver’s favor.

Now…

Shadow Weaver backhanded her. Rosa crumpled to the ground, wiping blood off her nose. “You insolent brat! How *dare* you?”

This… was not good.

She thought she had extinguished such pesky flares of emotion as the one that got her into this mess. She was not as free of flaw as she had believed.

Rosa resolved to neutralize this weakness immediately.

Actually… as soon as she got out of this situation.

“If there was one thing we got out of this mess, it is your work with Adora. I must admit it is…adequate. It may assist in helping the Horde recover.”

“They only got our tech,” Rosa insisted. “The dark magic division was unaffected.”

“Indeed,” Shadow Weaver sneered. “And of course they will dig us out of this disaster you’ve landed the Horde in, with me at their helm.”

You vile, repulsive little…

“I see,” Rosa said, carefully blank. “And how do you propose we accomplish this?”

Even with the ugly mask, Rosa could tell Shadow Weaver was smirking. “A certain spell I know. I just need a component. And I know just the operative to get it for me.”

. . .

“So that meeting was unproductive,” Catra grumbled, tightening her cloak around her neck. Frigid rain streaked through the forest, soaking the two travelers as they walked down the rough path.

“Yes, it was,” Karma agreed wearily. “Hopefully the next will be better. We should be there in a few hours.”

Catra’s ears flicked in irritation.

Suddenly, her mismatched eyes widened. “Is that-“

“What?” Karma asked her urgently. “What do you see?”

“… *Adora* ?”

Chapter End Notes

In case it’s not clear, the chapter title comes from the part when Catra’s like “join or die”. Saw Ben Franklin’s cartoon of the same name and it just made me think of the stupid argument in season one “princess are stronger on their own”. That made no sense to me.

This chapter is mostly just a bridge to the next one.

Buckle up folks, it’s going to a wild ride.

The Catradora Runs Rampant

Chapter Notes

So I’m still alive.

…merry Christmas?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

At first, Karma dismisssed it as a trick of the light.

But then lightning flashed overhead, illuminating the girl’s face.

It was undoubtedly Adora.

“Kitten?” Karma whispered, voicing cracking.

Adora stared at them, face blank, before her expression tightened and she dashed away.

“Wait!” Catra cried out, stretching out a hand beseechingly. Adora payed her no mind, disappearing into the Crystal Castle.

Without a word, Catra and Karma darted between the closing doors.

Inside, Adora was yelling. “Hello?” she called, voice echoing. “Is anyone here?”

A hologram appeared, causing Adora to shriek. “Greetings, administrator. What is your query?”

“Ghost!” Adora squeaked. “I-uh-“

“What is your query?” the hologram repeated.

“Uh- for the Honor Of Greyskull!” Adora yelped, becoming She-Ra in a flash of light.

“Administrator detected. Hello, She-Ra.”

“Adora!” Catra yelled, drawing the blonde’s attention. “What are you doing here?”

She-Ra started. “What- how do you know my name?!”

For the first time in her life, Catra was at a loss for words. “You’re kidding me, right?”

“Kitten?” Karma said hesitantly.

“What?” She-Ra responded, baffled. “No, I’m a human? Who even are you?”

“You don’t remember us?!” Catra shrieked. “What- how-“

Karma growled, a low, feral tone that resonated through the Castle. “I’ll bet five gold pieces it’s the Horde’s doing.”

A new suspicion entered She-Ra’s eyes. “Wait, are you princesses?”

“ *You’re* a princess!” Catra cried, exasperated. “Basically!”

“I’m a loyal Horde soldier!” She-Ra barked. “Stop *lying* to me!”

“I’m going to gut the Shady Lady!” Catra said, baring her fangs.

“You had *better* not be talking about Shadow Weaver! She’s a fantastic person!”

“That- her *name alone* seems evil!”

“ *How dare you* -“

“Unauthorized presence detected. Security protocol activated.”

The room turned red and the doors began to close.

“No, no, no, not again!” Catra spat.

“What just happened?” Karma questioned, grabbing Catra and She-Ra.

“Let go of me, I- agh!” She-Ra cut off as spiders poured out of a nearby room. “Truce! Truce! Turn it off!”

“Truce accepted, but we don’t control this place,” Catra growled, tugging them all through a door to escape the spiders.

The lights continued to shut off, spiders screeching in the inky blackness.

“What's going on?” She-Ra panted. “Why are those things trying to kill us?”

“Bad manners?” Catra deadpanned. “I really don’t think the why matters all that much.”

They rounded a corner only to see a dead end, all of them sliding to a stop with the spiders hot on their heels.

“Great, what now?” Catra groaned.

She-Ra narrowed her eyes. “Stand back!” She used her sword to bring down the ceiling on the spiders before transforming it into a shield to protect Karma, Catra, and herself.

“Thanks,” Catra gasped, eyes still blown wide from panic.

“Um, you’re welcome,” She-Ra replied awkwardly. “Why are you here, anyway? I mean, how did you even find this place?”

“We saw you and followed you in,” Catra explained. “How’d *you* find this place?”

“Shadow Weaver.”

“Ugh, hate her.”

“Hey!” She-Ra snapped.

“She kidnapped me, my siblings, and my girlfriend. And then tortured my sister and brainwashed my girlfriend. I think I’m valid.”

“You’re taken?” She-Ra blurted. “Wait, not important. Shadow Weaver wouldn’t do that!”

“I’ve met her like twice and I can safely say she does stuff like that all the time, probably.”

“She does like she drowns puppies for fun,” Karma agreed. “Psycho old hag.”

“Stop talking about her like that!” She-Ra snapped. “She’s basically my mom!”

Karma looked like she’d been punched in the stomach for a split second before she schooled her expression. “I’m sorry, Adora. I’ll keep my opinions to myself.”

“Thank you,” She-Ra responded loftily.

“Those things will be back soon,” Karma said, voice dull. “We should get out of here.”

. . .

“Another dead end,” She-Ra groaned.

“I don’t think it is,” Catra said. “Can you read the word on the door?”

“What, they don’t teach you how to read in the Rebellion?” She-Ra scoffed.

“First Ones’ writing isn’t commonly taught,” Karma explained. “My- I know a young woman who’s quite proficient at it, though.”

“Huh,” She-Ra said. “Sounds like a nerd.”

Catra muffled a snort.

“Eternia,” She-Ra read off the door. It opened to reveal an unnaturally dark room.

“Cheery,” Catra said sarcastically. “This must be the infinite darkness room.”

They walked in, relying on She-Ra for light.

“Well, this is giving me the creeps,” Catra announced. “I’m out- Wait, where’s the door?”

When Karma and She-Ra turned, they too saw the door was gone.

“Okay… that’s freaky.” She-Ra admitted. “Wait-do you see that?”

“The red thing?” Karma questioned. “What do you think it is?”

“Dunno,” She-Ra said, walking closer to it.

“Adora, be careful!” Catra warned, rushing to grab She-Ra’s wrist. “It looks like-“

The red light flared so bright it caused all three women to cover the eyes. When Catra uncovered her eyes, she realized she was alone with Adora in the Fright Zone.

“No!” Catra blurted. “Nope, nope, actually, no, I *hate* this place. We can’t actually be here. This is like, a Shady Lady trick or something.”

“I doubt it.” Adora scoffed. “Now let go of me!”

Before Catra could react, a tiny version of the catlike woman ran past them.

“Get back here you *brat* !” a buff violet woman snarled, chasing the younger Catra.

“Make me!”

“What…” Adora said, looking lost.

The purple woman scooped up Little Catra, holding her away from herself with disgust. “Dirty mongrel.”

“Let me GO!” Little Catra hissed, writhing. “You dumb faces need to take me *home* !”

“This is your home,” the Horde woman replied coldly. “Now get back to your bunk.”

“I don’t know where it is,” Little Catra muttered.

“I can show you!” a new voice piped up.

The Horde soldier, Adora, and both Catras looked down the hall to see a small blonde girl dressed in Horde red. “I’m Adora! What’s your name?”

Little Catra slowed her struggling, then sullenly replied, “Catra.”

“C’mon!” Little Adora said cheerfully, offering her hand. “I bet we’re going to be good friends!”

The Fright Zone flickered away and Adora and Catra were left standing in Bright Moon.

“What was that?” Adora asked, voice shaking slightly.

Catra inhaled sharply, ears flicking slightly. “I think that was a memory.”

. . .

Karma found herself in her old village facing her first love.

"Felix," she whispered, staring into her late husband's face.

He looked just as she remembered- dark black-brown fur, icy blue eyes that matched Catra's right. He was wearing simple clothes, perfect for moving and fighting.

Karma's stomach turned to ice. She knew what day this was.

Felix walked *through* her, and she spun to see him approach another her. A visibly pregnant her.

"Oh," she said softly.

Felix leaned to kiss Younger Karma's protruding belly, causing her to laugh fondly. "You going to miss me, little one?"

"I don't know that she can hear you yet," Younger Karma teased.

"'She'?" Felix repeated, amused. "You sure it's a girl?"

Younger Karma shrugged. “Just a feeling.”

Felix smiled. “I can’t wait to meet her. Our little Catra.”

“ *Catra* ?” Younger Karma echoed. “Love, we are part cat. We cannot name our child Catra.”

“Why not?” Felix said mischievously. “Our angel queen’s name is Angella. It’s a practically a homage to her.”

“Naming our child a stupid name is a homage to the queen,” Younger Karma deadpanned, raising an eyebrow.

“Absolutely!” Felix grinned. “If you hate it so much, come up with a better name.”

“Fine,” Younger Karma agreed. “When you come back, I’ll have a *much* better name.”

“I never did come up with another name,” Older Karma whispered, watching herself interact lovingly with her deceased husband. “And you never came back.”

She blinked back tears. “It hurt,” she admitted to herself. “It still hurts, knowing you’re not there. You should have grown old with

me. And I will always love you, Felix."

She sighed, rubbing her neck. "But… I think I've fallen in love again… does that make me a bad person? It's been nineteen years. I won't ever forget you… but I think I can go on."

For a moment, it seemed the illusionary Felix met her gaze, and then the projection dissolved.

. . .

The familiar halls of Bright Moon were at once soothing and alarming to Catra.

Soothing, because Bright Moon was her home- warm, friendly, beckoning.

Alarming, because there was something *off* about the sight. She couldn't quite put her finger on it. Perhaps it was the fact the palace looked as it had eight years ago, or maybe it was the knowledge that this wasn't quite *real* .

"I know this place," She-Ra whispered.

Catra huffed. "Yeah."

She-Ra swung her head sharply, obviously having overheard Catra's muttered remark. "Where is this?"

"Bright Moon."

A preteen Catra ran into the hall, spitting mad. A more subdued but no less emotional young Adora trailed after her, blinking back tears.

"Catra-"

"No!" Younger Catra half yelled, half cried. "I'm not apologizing!"

"You didn't mean it!"

"I *did* !" Younger Catra spat. "It's *her fault* , Adora!"

"It isn't Mama's fault!" Younger Adora yelled back.

"She's the general! Of course it's her fault Dad's-". Younger Catra's seized, and she choked, her mismatched eyes swelling with tears. "That Dad's-"

“That he’s-“

“DON’T SAY IT!”

Younger Catra’s shoulders rose and fell in great heaves, her furious expression disrupted somewhat by the tears dripping down her face. “He isn’t! He can’t be!”

“Catra-“

“LEAVE ME ALONE!” Younger Catra lashed out, lightly scratching Younger Adora’s cheek.

“Hey!” She-Ra complained, almost reflexively.

Catra winced. “Yeah, sorry about that. Wasn’t in a good place.”

“Obviously.”

“…I’m no longer sorry.”

She-Ra gave a small, startled laugh.

Meanwhile, Younger Adora flinched, then seemed to steel herself. “I’m not leaving you Catra. Please don’t let me lose you too.”

Younger Catra crumpled, sobbing into Younger Adora’s shoulder. “I miss Dad…”

“Me too.”

The moment was interrupted as a robotic spider roared, tearing through the illusion.

“Adora!” Catra cried, grabbing She-Ra.

“Get off me!”

“Fine!” Catra leapt on top of the spider, tearing through its eye to the circuitry beneath. “Die, stupid thing!”

She-Ra stabbed it with a sword. “I can do this by myself!”

“So?!” Catra shouted. “Just because you can doesn’t mean you should!”

“And why would it be better to be with you?” She-Ra shot back. “I don’t need you!” She turned away, eyes growing hard. “I’m sick of this place.”

“And where are you going to go, the Horde?!” Catra cried. “You don’t belong there.”

“Of course I do!”

The world around them flickered, and they were suddenly in Bright Moon again. A tiny Catra raced by them, giggling.

“THIS IS JUST A STUPID PRINCESS TRICK!” She-Ra roared. Her transformation slipped, and Adora stood, uncertain, surrounded by forgotten memories.

“Wait up, Catra!” Tiny Adora called, dashing by the two women.

“What’s it like being the slowest person ever?” Tiny Catra taunted, throwing Tiny Adora a mischievous grin over her shoulder.

“I dunno, how is it, Catra?” Tiny Lonnie said. “Seeing as I was here first!”

“No you weren’t!” Glimmer argued. “I was!”

“You cheated!”

“No I DIDN’T!”

“Yes you-“

“ENOUGH!” Present Adora wailed. The projections froze. “I don’t understand! Why are you doing this?”

Catra took a step forward. “Adora, I would do anything for you. And I know you’d do anything for me. We made a promise.”

“I don’t remember you at all!”

“And that’s Shadow Weaver’s fault!”

“How can I trust you? I don’t know you at all-“

“But *I know you* ,” Catra interrupted firmly, her eyes gleaming with determination. “You’re a fantastic best friend. You always feel the need to be perfect. You can’t ever stop being the hero, because it’s who you *are* . You’re the best person I know and I won’t ever leave you, not again. So *don’t you dare leave me* .”

“I…” Adora looked frozen, uncertainty dancing across her face. “I don’t…”

Karma barreled into the room. “Kittens!” She exclaimed in relief. Her expression shifted slightly. “Adora, do you…”

“I…” Adora looked up slowly. “I need to think.” She was swallowed suddenly by inky darkness.

“Adora!” Catra cried.

“Kitten?!”

After a moment of frantic searching to no avail, Karma’s ears pricked.

“Sunshine, I don’t think we’re alone.”

Chapter End Notes

I’m not super proud of this chapter. It’s kinda filler. We do get some interesting questions, though!

First one to guess who Karma is interested in wins absolutely nothing.

Light Hope Fails At Being A Therapist

Chapter Notes

… so it's been a while.

oops.

…enjoy?

Pugna considered herself a good soldier.

She followed orders. She protected her squad mates. She did her best to win at the end of the day.

But good soldiers weren't supposed to have questions.

The princesses weren't anything like she had expected. They were too *nice* . It didn't make sense. Everyone said that they were horrible, cruel people enslaving everyone.

Her allies- her *friends* - wouldn't lie to her… right?

~~A dark voice in her head told her yes.~~

The thing about asking someone if they're lying is that they can just lie. Again. Since that was off the table, she was resorting to

more extreme measures, namely following the Horde's newest operative.

Pugna knew she wasn't exactly the brightest, but even she realized She-Ra suddenly working for them was… weird. Suspicious, really.

So that led her to where she was now. Having followed She-Ra to this weird *death trap* castle, seeing bits and pieces of her worst memories.

She-Ra seemed… really confused. ~~Like she'd been brainwashed .~~ Beside her was Princess Catra and General Karma, two of the highest on the Horde's Most Wanted list.

Two voices were screaming inside of her. Her loyalty, her training, it all told her to attack, to protect the Horde.

Her doubts said *wait* .

But she was a good soldier.

The Horde came first.

Pugna lunged.

. . .

As ~~Mama~~ the Rebel general was knocked to the floor, ~~Catra~~ the Rebel soldier screamed. The general's attacker bore a Horde uniform. That was ~~bad~~ good.

Operative She-Ra seized the distraction and darted away, intent on finishing her mission without Rebellion interference. The fight fell away as she entered a new room. This one was long and crystalline and completely empty. Good.

"Hello, Adora."

She-Ra yelped, spinning around. Her transformation dropped. There was a strange glowing lady that *definitely* hadn't been there a second ago.

"How does everyone *know my name* ?!" Adora complained. "And… who are you?"

"I am Light Hope," the woman said. "I have been waiting for you since you were an infant, but I could not reach you. And I could not protect you from the Horde. I watched you grow up from afar."

“Wow, that's--that's kind of creepy, honestly.” Adora mumbled. “And I *don’t* need protection from the Horde! They’re the good guys!”

“Ah,” Light Hope responded. “Your databanks have been corrupted.”

“My data-what?”

“Your memory storage.”

“No it isn’t!” Adora insisted. “Stop trying to trick me!”

“Can you form a full timeline of events from the past three cycles?” Light Hope inquired.

“Of course I… can?” Adora paused, her face freezing. Her memory beyond the past day was… fuzzy. More words than actual events.

You are a loyal Horde soldier. You see Shadow Weaver as a mother. You highly respect Force Captain Rosa. The Princesses are evil.

There was no evidence to back up the claims, merely the claims themselves.

“Oh great,” Adora moaned. “My life is a lie. Is anything real? Are you? Am *I*?”

“I can confirm I am-“

“Be quiet and let me have an existential crisis, please.”

. . .

“Tina?” Kyle called, peering into the woods. The Horde girl slipped out of the shadows, smiling shyly at him before her face grew solemn.

“Hey, Kyle,” she said. “I have bad news and more bad news.”

Kyle blanched. “That’s not encouraging. But first, do you know what happened to Adora?”

Tina flinched. “That’s part of the bad news.”

Kyle’s face lost its remaining color. “She-she isn’t-“

"No!" Tina hurried to say. "She's not dead."

Kyle sighed in relief. "Thank goodness."

"Yeah, I phrased that badly," Tina admitted. "But the thing is… I think Rosa… brainwashed her somehow."

"Is that *possible* ?!"

"I've heard rumors," said Tina. "Never believed them before. But it's kind of hard to deny She-Ra suddenly working for the Horde."

Kyle froze, then turned. "I have to tell my family."

"Wait!" Tina grabbed his arm. "That's not the worst of it."

"How does it get *worse* ?!"

"They're planning to use She-Ra's 'betrayal' as a distraction- for a full scale attack on Bright Moon."

. . .

“Mama!” Catra yelled, darting for the attacker. She slashed a long mark down the girl’s arm.

“Ow!” the Horde girl roared. “Hey!”

Karma wrestled her to the floor. After pinning her, she gave her a long, hard look. “What are you doing here, kid?”

“I-I…” the girl stammered. “I was…”

“Mama!” Catra cried again suddenly. “Adora’s gone.”

Karma swore, looking over at her daughter. As she did, Pugna surged upwards, throwing Karma off her. She made a break for the door, leaving the two catlike women behind.

“Should we follow her?” Catra asked.

“I think we have bigger problems,” Karma said, as spiders began to fill the room.

. . .

Glimmer was pacing, frustrated, while Willow sat by Bow watching, concern shining in her violet eyes.

“Shouldn’t they be back by now?” Glimmer ranted, occasionally interrupted by painful-looking glitches. “They said they were gonna find some contacts and find Adora, and-OW!” she roared, stumbling over a chair. “And what kind of *monster* puts a chair here?!”

“Okay, I'm worried, too, Glimmer, but taking it out on the furniture isn't going to help.” Bow said. “Though… maybe you’re right. They should have been back by now… maybe they found a lead?”

“Or maybe they’re in trouble!” Glimmer yelled. “I can’t just *sit* here while my mama and sisters are in trouble!”

“But what could we even do?” Bow pointed out. “We don’t even know where they are.”

Their argument was cut off as a knock sounded on the door. “Princess?” a guard’s voice said. “There's, uh, something here to see you.”

“Don't you mean someone?” Glimmer replied, confused.

“No. I mean something.”

A swift *clop-clop-clop* announced the arrival of a pure white alicorn with rainbow wings. Glimmer and Bow’s eyes grew wide, while Willow just ran and hugged the horse.

“What’s Adora’s horse doing here?” Bow wondered.

“I am my own horse.” the horse declared. “Call me-“ he deepened his voice in an attempt to sound more regal- “Swift Wind!”

Glimmer and Bow screamed.

“Since when can Adora’s horse talk!” Bow gasped.

Swift Wind’s face flattened to a deadpan. “Yeah, yeah, I can speak my mind now, pretty crazy-SO, I was thinking-“

Bow was clearly still stuck on the previous revelation. “He's a talking hoOoOoOrse!”

Swift Wind looked irritated. “As we've established. Now, I think I can find Adora. Since Adora transformed me, I've been able to feel where she is at all times. It's like instinct. But now I feel a pull, as if I'm being summoned to her side.”

Bow touched Swift Wind's wing and gasped, ecstatic. “You are *so cool* .”

Swift Wind preened. “Yes I am. Anyways, as part of Adora's herd, I need your help. Will you come?

Glimmer glitched, then hummed committedly. “Of course. Lead the way.”

“Um, shouldn’t we send the others?” Bow said sensibly. “You know, because you’re glitching.”

“I’m going with or without you,” Glimmer declared. “Are you with me?”

Bow sighed. “Always. But… I don't think your mom is going to like us leaving so soon after our last mission.”

“Well, Mama’s missing too,” Glimmer said. “ *Someone* needs to run the kingdom. Therefore, this seems like a job for *our* group. Besides, we don’t have to tell Mom- we’ll be back before she knows.”

Glimmer opened the door to find Angella standing there.

Glimmer immediately glitched. “Mom!”

Angella cleared her throat, looking distinctly unimpressed.

Glimmer laughed nervously, fidgeting with her cloak. “What are you doing here?”

Angella raised an eyebrow. “Coming to see why my guard was escorting a horse into your room.”

“I like to think of myself more as a role model for all horse kind.” Swift Wind interjected self-importantly. Then, reading the looks on Glimmer and Bow’s faces, he added, “ ...I mean, uh, what talking horse?” He laughed nervously. “What's happening?”

Angella sighed. “Look, I’m going to assume you found something out.”

“Yes!” Glimmer burst out. “Swift Wind can find Adora!”

“Who’s Swift Wind?” Angella asked.

“The horse.”

“All right then. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Seneschal should go find her.”

“Not me?” Glimmer protested.

Angella regarded her flatly. “Glimmer. You are recovering from magical damage we don’t fully understand. This isn’t about your capabilities or implying any lack thereof, you are merely on mandatory rest.”

Glimmer groaned, but nodded. “Fine. I’ll go get the *functional* and Mom-approved people.”

“Uh, when we're back, I'd like to talk about freeing all the horses in your stables.” Swift Wind interjected. “I think it’s seriously-“

“You’ve got a mission, c’mon,” Bow told him. “Later, buddy.”

. . .

Adora stood up, clearing her throat. “Sorry about that…uh, I don't want to be rude, but, um...who are you?”

“I am Light Hope, Etheria's facilitator. I was created by the First Ones, as you call them.”

Adora blinked. “Okay, quick follow-up...who are the First Ones?”

“The First Ones were explorers who journeyed from beyond the stars to settle Etheria.” Light Hope explained. “They built this place for you...the Crystal Castle.”

Light Hope suddenly appeared next to the blonde. Adora jumped, squeaking slightly. “For *me* ? Why?”

“Because you are special,” Light Hope said. “Adora, I've waited so long for you, and now the time has come to show you your destiny.”

“My… destiny?” Adora repeated. “Light Hope, do you know who I am?”

“You are She-Ra, Etheria's champion, appointed by the First Ones to protect and unite our planet.” Light Hope replied. “There have been many before you, but the line was broken. You are the first She-Ra in a thousand years.”

“Everything on Etheria is connected.” Light Hope continued. As she spoke, holograms of each of the princesses appeared. “The princesses are granted power over the elements through their

Runestones. As She-Ra, it is your duty to bring the princesses together. Only then can balance be restored to Etheria."

Adora gasped slightly as her hand went through a holographic silhouette of a pink princess. "That sounds great, but the thing is–"

"You are correct. It is great." Light Hope said. "When the princesses and their elements are in balance, Etheria functions as it should." Projections suddenly began to show the Horde and its actions. Adora gaped. *This* was what she had been defending?! No wonder the cute cat girl hated them! "But the Horde is destroying us in their quest for power. There is no predicting what they will do next."

"I…" Adora swallowed. "Wow. This is… a lot." She felt a little like she was drowning, secrets and facts and lies pouring from the heavens and pulling her under. Nervously, she straightened her ponytail.

Light Hope cocked her head. "Is there something you do not understand? I can start again from the beginning, if you would like."

"No, that's-"

"I am Light Hope, Etheria's facilitator–" Light Hope began again.

Adora sighed. “No, no, I got it.”

“Have I mentioned that you are chosen?”

“Yeah, it’s come up. But *why me* ?”

Light Hope stared at her. “I do not understand the question.”

“I mean, look at me!” Adora shouted, suddenly upset. “I don’t even know who I am! I have all these feelings and thoughts and they *don’t agree* . Do you have any idea how *terrifying* that is? My head tells me to attack the cat girl, that she’s an enemy, but something else says she’s *important* , and I hate myself for even *thinking* of touching her! I can’t even trust myself!”

“Adora, you do not yet realize the power you have.” Light Hope rested her hand on Adora’s shoulder, glitching where it touched her. “You are distracted by your attachments. There was one before you who could not let go. Her name was Mara.”

“Mara? What happened to her?”

“Mara was the last She-Ra before you.” Light Hope said. “She struggled with a power that she could not control. Until it became too much for her mind.”

“I think we can safely say *my* mind is not okay,” Adora mumbled. Then, louder, she said: “She snapped?”

“She was compromised.” responded Light Hope. “She gave in to fear and faulty reasoning. Her desperate actions led to devastation. Mara stranded us in the empty dimension of Despandos. She broke the She-Ra line. She nearly destroyed us.

”...Adora. I have waited here for a thousand years alone. I did not know if I would ever see another She-Ra. You must stay here and train. Learn to be the She-Ra that Mara could not be.”

“I don’t know how to do that!” Adora shouted. “I don’t even know how to be *me* ! Look, I don’t know why you chose me, but choose someone else!”

“It must be you,” Light Hope replied. “You have no choice.”

Adora’s eyes filled with tears. “There’s *always* a choice. There has to be!”

“There isn’t.”

Adora choked, falling to her knees. Voices pounded in her head, conflicting and building in volume.

Fight for the Horde-

Love you, kitten-

Be safe-

Loyal soldier-

We're the good guys-

Make yourself useful-

Why would they want you-

not enough not enough how can you ever be enough save everyone fight for the Horde the Horde are wrong you're wrong wrong wrong ***wrong*** *-*

Hey, Adora.

The whisper of a memory cut through the din. Adora could almost see the mismatched eyes glowing with concern.

My dummy…

She didn’t understand it, but the impression buoyed her up, lifting her out of her thoughts.

Adora straightened, resolve strengthened anew. “Okay. Okay. I can do this.”

…

“… and then I realized I'm free, but the other horses aren't. So I named myself Swift Wind after the swift winds of revolution and left to go kick down stable doors. Freedom, equality, and hay for all!”

“Please shut up,” Lonnie said. “I’m begging you.”

“I find it quite fascinating, actually!” Seneschal piped up.

‘Love you’ Rogelio signed. ‘But no. Horse shuts up.’

“What’s he saying?” Swift Wind asked. “I don’t speak Hand.”

“Well, I guess it’s hard when you don’t *have* hands,” Lonnie acknowledged.

Swift Wind’s horn lit up with magic. “Oh hey! There! She's over there!”

They stared at the Crystal Castle. “Um, how are we supposed to get in?” Seneschal asked, scratching his head.

“Wait...wait!” Swift Wind said. “I know this. Hang on, I think I can–“ He touched his horn to the castle. A door rumbled open, and the castle glowed red.

“Red. That’s a great sign,” Lonnie said sarcastically.

“Uh...this way!” Swift Wind said, gesturing with his head. They made their way through the castle. Suddenly, Lonnie grabbed Rogelio’s arm, pointing out an unconscious Adora.

“Adora!” Lonnie cried, running to her side.

“I think I can reach her.” Swift Wind held his horn to Adora’s head. “Hold on.”

“Great, now the horse is out of commission,” said Lonnie flatly. She paused, listening to spiders chitter. “And I think we’re about to be attacked. Awesome.”

. . .

The room around her started to glitch, including Light Hope. Adora cried out, panicking. “Light Hope? Light Hope, come back! I don't--I don't know what to do.”

“Adora… ADORA!”

An alicorn appeared out of nowhere. Adora blinked. The horse was still there.

“Uh… what?”

“Hi Adora! I'm Swift Wind.”

Adora blinked. “Are horses *supposed* to be able to talk?”

“Absolutely.” Swift Wind replied

“Really? That doesn’t seem right…”

“Look, we gotta go,” Swift Wind told her. “Where’s the exit?”

Adora shrugged helplessly. “I don't know. Light Hope disappeared and I-I don't know if I should go back.”

“What do you mean?”

“I don’t know who I am! What I’m supposed to do!”

“Well, that's just stupid.” Swift Wind deadpanned.

“What?” Adora said incredulously. “No, it's not.”

“Look, you have people who will help you figure it out! Me, the queens, your girlfriend-“

“-I have a girlfriend?!”

“Oh right, amnesia,” Swift Wind mused. “Well, you do! Lots of people love and miss you, and will be there for you whatever happens.”

“I don’t know if I believe you,” Adora said. “But I’m willing to try.”

She woke up.

The Horde VS The Rebellion! FIGHT!!

Chapter Notes

…yeah, I have no excuses. This is really late.

And there's more bad news at the end. Sorry.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora woke to utter chaos.

Mechanical bugs were facing off against the cat ladies, a sorceress, some lizard dude, and a hippie. The first three were unsurprisingly good fighters, the fourth seemed to be in the process of reprogramming one of the bugs, and the fifth was just hitting things with a woven mat.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora yelled, raising her sword.

With She-Ra's help, they were able to clear through the spiders fairly quickly. As soon as the last one was crushed, she dropped her transformation.

"Adora!" Catra cried, flinging herself at the surprised blond.

"Don't you have a girlfriend?" Adora questioned. "Wait, don't *I* have a girlfriend?"

Catra laughed, almost hysterically. “Ah, right, sorry, my bad.”

“Is this some weird new flirting thing?” the sorcereress sked. “You’re acting kinda weird, Adora.”

“I…” Adora hesitated. “Look. I don’t remember anything, and I don’t really know what’s real right now. But… I’m willing to hear you guys out.”

“Wait, are you saying you have *amnesia* ?!” the sorceress said incredulously.

‘Not good’ signed the lizard man. ‘You okay?’

“Not really?” Adora sighed. “I’m figuring it out.”

A pale blonde burst into the room. “Guys!” He panted out. “The Horde…” he hesitated. “It’s really better you see for yourselves.” He froze. “Wait, is Adora back on our side?”

“How did you even know about that, Kyle?” the sorceress said, eyebrow raised. “ *We* didn’t.”

“Not important right now,” Kyle dismissed.

“I’m figuring things out,” Adora asserted. She paused. “Wait, who are you?”

“Shelving *that* aside…” Kyle sighed. “Seriously. Look outside.”

. . .

“ *Wow* ,” Catra choked out. “How did they even-“

“Apparently? Ametuer sorcerers,” Kyle cut in. “Taught them to set stuff on fire and set them off in the general direction of Bright Moon.”

“Crude, but apparently effective,” Karma muttered, watching the Whispering Woods burn with haunted eyes. The soft twilight colors of the forest were being consumed with black flames that twisted and roared unnaturally.

“Now there’s nothing between the Horde and Bright Moon,” Seneschal breathed.

“We need to get back to Bright Moon,” Lonnie said determinedly. “Fast.”

She paused. “Wait, we only have one horse and there’s six of us.”

“Don’t I count?” Swift Wind asked, offended.

“You’re the horse.”

Karma inhaled slowly, mulling over the problem. Then her eyes narrowed as she came to a decision. “Lonnie, Catra, and I should go. We’re the most combat inclined. Adora should also come- the castle’s doctors may be able to help her.”

“And I get to come too?” Swift Wind checked.

His only answer was a deadpan glare from Karma.

. . .

“The Horde are coming,” Angella said grimly. Glimmer glared at the map, as if ill intent alone could turn back the troops represented by the holograms. “We’re vastly outnumbered. Our high general is missing, as is several of our best combatants.”

Bow broke the ensuing silence. “Well, shoot.”

Angella sighed. “I’ll admit, this does not look good.”

Karma burst into the room. “Sorry we’re late,” she said briskly. “We had a few complications.”

“Karma,” Angella said, relieved. “Did you find Adora?” Hope tinged her voice, her face, by contrast, was visibly anxious.

Karma hesitated, then nodded. “Yes… but she will be… unavailable, for a bit. She’s…” Karma faltered, strong facade cracking for just the tiniest moment, “amnesiac.”

“But she’s okay, right?” Angella asked, tone bordering on desperate.

“Yes,” Karma confirmed with a nod.

Angella took a steadying breath. “Then we must proceed forward with our plans. We may not have She-Ra’s help, but we’ve managed without her before.”

“The Horde has gotten more effective recently,” General Juliet cautioned. “Their leadership is stronger than it’s been in years. This is not going to be an easy fight.”

“Just because it isn’t easy doesn’t mean it’s impossible,” Glimmer said, eyes gleaming determinedly. “We just need a good plan.”

“Anyone have any ideas?” Bow asked.

A smirk spread slowly across Karma’s face. “I have a few.”

. . .

Bow squinted at the battlefield through the haze of flashing lights and smoke from broken tanks.

As it turned out, some of the tanks and bots had escaped the EMP. Entrapta had mentioned that was a possibility- something about cages?- and that the Horde might have some of their technology protected. The hows didn’t matter so much to Bow, only that the tanks were there and a very real threat to his friends.

He notched an arrow, training it on the advancing tank.

After the first few shots he’d taken, in which he had disabled three bots and a tank, the Horde had posted soldiers with some sort of long, flat shields in front of the tanks’ and bots’ weak points. This strategy would have been effective, as moving from his position on the roof would be time consuming and leave him exposed. Fortunately for them, they had a plan.

To no one’s surprise, Spinnerella and Netossa worked beautifully as a team. The soldiers protecting the Horde’s tech soon found themselves bowled over by sudden gales or pinned by nets. Any attempt at retribution would find itself viciously met by the wrath of a protective partner.

With the two women clearing the way, it was no time at all until Bow had a straight shot. Tanks and bots fell one after another, their groaning metal clattering to the ground with mighty crashes. Occasionally, one would get the idea to fire at the archer (and really, shouldn’t they have been doing that all along? Were the majority of the Horde morons?) and he would have to dodge. But for the most part, everything was going well.

Until he heard a click behind him, and turned to see Rosa, stun baton leveled at his head.

Shoot.

. . .

Meanwhile, Catra and Lonnie were locked in a furious duel with the magic users. The fight was fairly well matched- while the Horde vastly outnumbered the two, almost all of their sorcerers were novices who messed up most spells. On the other hand, Lonnie was a prodigy and Catra had been training for years. The fumbling mages weren’t individually a fraction of the challenge fighting her sisters was.

Still, two against a couple hundred was a tough fight no matter the skill level, and Lonnie was starting to flag. Prolonged combat wasn't exactly a common occurrence at Mystacor; most of the sparring came in the form of duels that lasted at most ten minutes. There was an orderliness that this fight utterly lacked, more strategy than the absolute chaos of a real battlefield.

Catra noticed her sister tiring and growled, slashing her claws at an enemy's helmet just a bit harder than perhaps necessary. There wasn't much she could do to help Lonnie-she was overwhelmed herself.

Suddenly, the soldiers around her toppled as a new group crashed through them. She grinned, relieved- Glimmer's force had arrived.

After the nearby Rebellion camp had been summoned, the army had been divided up into three groups. Karma led one, General Juliet led the second, and Glimmer had managed to convince the generals to put her in charge of the third. It had been an uphill battle- neither of Glimmer's parents were exactly thrilled to see her run off while her powers were out of commission.

"My powers are not the only skill I have!" Glimmer had shouted. *"I may not be able to blast soldiers with sparkles, but I know how to lead!"*

Their mothers exchanged a long look, as Glimmer stood, chin raised, eyes flashing with defiance and pride. *"We're very proud of*

you, Glimmer," Angella had said, smiling at her daughter.

"You never- wait, what?" Glimmer had broken off, defensive stance dropping.

"You're right, kitten," Karma told her. *"You're a more than capable leader."*

Seeing her now, Catra was inclined to agree with Karma's assessment.

Glimmer looked like an avenging angel, or at least an angel with anger management issues given a staff and free reign. She and her troops bulldozed through the unsuspecting soldiers already battered by Catra. Glimmer caught Catra's eye and grinned. " *Point to me* ," she mouthed.

Catra had enough time to stick out her tongue before she was pulled back into the fight.

It could have been seconds later or even a full hour-time had a tendency to blur together in a fight- when she heard the scream. Her head snapped up, almost getting hit by a fireball. Absently she swatted the mage it came from, focus diverted to the sight in front of her.

Rosa held an unconscious bow in a chokehold, dangling him over the edge of the palace roof. Pugna hovered behind her, probably to guard from Glimmer teleporting up and attacking Rosa.

Not that that's a problem , Catra thought almost bitterly. *But* Rosa *doesn't know that.*

"Leaders of this so-called *Rebellion* ," Rosa called, eyes glinting in a way that didn't seem entirely sane. "Turn yourself over or the archer dies."

A growl rose in her throat. Catra *detested* feeling helpless- it was, in her opinion, one of the worst feelings in the world. But right now, there wasn't anything she could do. She was too far away to help. *Everyone* was. Even if they had to resort to catching Bow, no one with the capability of either breaking his fall or stopping it entirely- someone like Netossa, Spinnerella, Swist Wind or Angella- was close enough to get there in time. The first two were way across the battlefield, still tied up in a brutal fight with several bots, the winged horse was off trying to get back-up, and the latter was reinforcing the Moonstone. If she left her post, Bright Moon would fall. Angella couldn't let that happen, not even to save Bow.

It would take a *miracle* to help him.

. . .

Adora’s head hurt.

The doctor said it was to be expected, since someone was messing with her brain. Supposedly. Adora wasn’t sure who to believe. How could she *know* what was real, if even her memories couldn’t be trusted?

At least the kid they had left with her and the blonde guy for some reason was cute.

Willow sat beside her, chewing her lip. She tugged at her hair, eyebrows furrowing. “‘dora? Kyle?” she said hesitantly. “D’you think that Catra and Ro’lio and Lonnie and all the others will be okay?”

“I’m sure they’ll be fine, Willow,” Kyle consoled her. “They’re really brave and strong, right?”

“Yeah…” Willow bit her lip, eyes troubled. “But my mommy and daddy were really brave and strong too though, and they went away and when they came back they wouldn’t wake up.” She turned to Adora, beginning to cry. “I don’t want my new family to not be able to wake up!”

Not knowing what else to do, Adora awkwardly hugged the crying girl. “There, there… kid?”

“Can you go check on them?” Willow sniffled. “Make sure they’re okay?”

“I-uh…”

“You’re *She-Ra* ,” Willow said, gazing at her trustingly. “You can fight the Horde and make it all better. ‘Cause you’re *magic* .”

Adora wanted to argue that she didn’t remember that, didn’t know *how* to do that- she really did. But one look at Willow’s big, scared eyes and she caved. “Sure, kid. I’ll check.”

“Whoa,” Kyle said, grabbing her arm. “You’re still recovering! It’s not safe out there!”

She shook his grip off, glaring. “Of course it’s not safe! I’ll be *fine* . Just a quick glance, that’s all.”

He hesitated, clearly torn between wanting to follow her and not wanting to leave Willow alone. Finally, he nodded. “As long as it’s just a glance.”

It wasn’t.

Even in Adora's scrambled mind, dangling someone over a fatal drop wasn't exactly something the *good guys* do.

"Stop!" she commanded in a voice that barely seemed like her own. Pugna whirled around, amber eyes wide.

"How'd you get up here?!"

Adora blinked, momentarily caught off guard. "Uh, the stairs?"

"Oh- um- right," Pugna flushed. "Anyways, you need to leave!"

"No!" Adora snapped. "You're threatening to kill that guy! I'm not just going to let that happen!"

"Yes, you are," Rosa replied smoothly without turning. "She-Ra, welcome to the Horde. Now end this ridiculous rebellion!"

At those words, something *changed* inside her, almost like part of her deadened and fell quiet. The conflicting voices vanished, leaving only blissful clarity.

She was loyal to the Horde.

She was going to serve Rosa.

That was her *purpose* .

She took a step forward, intending to help Rosa.

And stopped.

As if from a long way off, an echoing voice rang in her head.
"Adora , don't. *"*

She grimaced, swatting lightly at her head as if the voice were a bothersome fly. She *had* to. She was loyal- she was!

"But loyal to who?"

Mismatched eyes, a low, sarcastic voice. A rare but brilliant smile, teasing remarks, fierceness and bravery and gruff kindness.

Catra.

Adora was loyal to Catra.

“She-Ra!” Rosa barked. “Do as I say!”

Again, the impulse to obey was so powerful as to be almost entirely overwhelming. She almost let the tide sweep her away, but a new image flashed into her mind.

Laughter, courage, sleepovers, arguments, sparring sessions, and so much love. Her siblings in all but name- Glimmer, Lonnie, Rogelio, Bow, and Kyle.

And that image was followed by more- serene elegance, bold protectiveness, unconditional love… her parents. How could she have forgotten her parents? Her whole *family*- Aunt Casta, Willow, the other princesses, all of them. It all came rushing back, snapping back into place.

Adora was loyal, sure.

Loyal to *them* .

“No,” she whispered.

“What?!” Rosa snapped, finally turning around. This had the fortunate side effect of getting Bow onto level ground.

"I said *no* ," Adora said, much more firmly. "I'm not going to betray them."

"She-Ra-"

"I may be She-Ra, but I'm *Adora* first," Adora snapped. She stalked up to Rosa."And I would *never* , *ever* hurt them. Not as long as I live."

Rosa's eyes widened, and for the first time since Adora had met the girl, she seemed truly taken aback. Then her eyes narrowed and her face twisted into an ugly snarl. "I should have known Shadow Weaver's brainwashing tactics were useless," she spat. "Fine. It seems you have outlived your usefulness." And she shoved her off the roof.

Adora shrieked, not expecting the sudden loss of support beneath her feet. As the ground came rushing up, she had just enough time for a terrible thought- *She-Ra won't protect her from gravity* .

And then there *was* something under her, but it was soft and yielding and bright pink.

Confused, she looked around and caught sight of Perfuma, Frosta, and Mermista, riding in on Swift Wind. She laughed, adrenaline making her head spin.

“Thank you!” she called out. “Now get Bow!”

After the reinforcements arrived, the battle’s tide was quickly shifted into their favor. It took less than ten minutes before the majority of the Horde’s forces were rounded up. Rosa, frustratingly, managed to get away somehow. Even still, it was a major victory for the Rebellion.

And as they gathered in Bright Moon’s kitchen, eating Kyle’s Victory Cake™, Adora felt overwhelmingly happy. They were safe from the Horde for a while as their forces recovered, her memories were back, and Glimmer’s illness (which, when did she get sick?! It seemed like she’d missed a lot…) had been cured by the energies aligning or whatever it was Entrapta had said. Adora didn’t really follow, but the hows weren’t as important as the fact that *Glimmer was okay* .

Even if things weren’t perfect, she thought, it was still pretty good. She had Catra and she had her family. And really, what else did she need?

Chapter End Notes

So… here’s the thing.
I’ve lost motivation for this story, I don’t really have time to write it, I’m not sure anyone cares anyways about this story, and, most importantly, I don’t think I’m doing justice to what I had envisioned. Now, I think that’s true for almost any work an author does, but in this case, I don’t think I have enough motivation to stick with it enough to make it good. So for those reasons I’m going to abandon this series. Feel free to

adopt it. I hope that it at least had a somewhat satisfying conclusion. Thank you for taking the time to read this.

End Notes

Does Catra actually believe they'll get out of trouble by bringing First Ones' tech back? Absolutely not. Is she going to say that just to get out of the castle? Absolutely yes.

Side note: Karma has a special nickname for all of her kittens. (Besides calling them all kittens, kiddos, and kids). Here's a quick reference:
Catra- Sunshine (because she's the original kiddo that got Karma through some rough times)
Adora- Daughter-in-law (see first work in the series)
Glimmer- Firecracker (because she's loud and sparkly and reminds Karma of firecrackers)
Lonnie- Little Moon (because she followed Micah around so much, like a moon orbiting a planet.)
Rogelio- Cutie (Karma worried that Rogelio would grow up self-conscious looking so different from his siblings so she wanted to remind him she thinks he is adorable)
Kyle- Sweetheart (double meaning. He bakes sweet things and is sweet himself)
Bow- Muffin (Literally no one knows. Bow doesn't care though)

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